beyond your reaches

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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by aswellingstorm

Summary

After defeating Horde Prime, Catra grapples with the ghosts of her past. The simple solution to building a perfect future seems to lie in traveling to the past and fixing her mistakes, but nothing can ever quite go according to plan.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

reverse midas touch

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was a stupid idea. Cursed at the offset, really. But there was just the slightest chance it might work and Catra had to take it. She has an escape route planned and a failsafe if anything should go *too* terribly wrong.

Which it already fucking has, she realizes after she collapses in the courtyard of Bright Moon. Not the Bright Moon she's come to know, but an older one. Not old enough, though. She hasn't traveled far back enough. *Shit*.

"This is bad," She grumbles, dusting herself off and moving to her feet. "Melog!"

Instantly, the two of them are turned invisible to the naked eye. There is just enough time for them to jump backwards, pressing against the outside wall of the palace as members of the Rebellion stroll past.

And *yep* -there's 'Flutterina' cheering enthusiastically over their win at Elberon. Catra definitely didn't go far back enough. And now she isn't sure how to go *further.* The rules of time travel are fast and loose, apparently, and Catra wasn't even sure if her half-scraps of a plan could even be a real possibility.

She should probably just use the blue gem in her bag to get back to her own time. Try again later, maybe. Once she understands how the magic works a bit better. But...she's already come this far. All she needs to do is figure out how to go further into the past.

Besides, if she goes back to her own time now, it will be empty handed. And she will have only caused Adora more senseless worry.

Catra winces, replaying the events of the previous night in her mind. She shouldn't have just run off like that, she knows that much, but everything was just...too much. Too much good, anyway.

Truthfully, it's all she has ever truly wanted, but now she isn't quite sure if she deserves it, this future that Adora has envisioned for them. She might be able to *be* worth it if she can just right her wrongs and get her shit together.

But getting her shit together is proving to be more difficult than originally planned. The one person who can *help* her technically isn't even here in Bright Moon just yet. And she can't go to them for help and risk compromising the timeline.

There is one person who might be able to help. Someone who has had their fair share of difficulties adhering to space and time: Madame Razz*.* The issue is that only Adora and Swift Wind know where to find her in the Whispering Woods. And if the Swift Wind from her time *barely* tolerated her now, even after well over two years of penance, there's no way *this* Swift Wind is going to help her.

She watches the horse in question slam their hooves into a table in the courtyard in a violent demonstration of how they fended off Horde soldiers.

"Yeah. He's useless." She deadpans.

Who can we ask, then? Melog wonders. Catra glances down at them as they flick their eyes to a certain someone, standing in the middle of the group, looking tired and battle worn.

"Absolutely not," she hisses.

This Adora must be avoided at all costs. Despite what her future self may claim, Adora from this time *hates* her. For good reason, too.

Catra grimaces as the words, in all of their final damnation, echo in her mind. *"You made your choice. Now live with it!"*

And yeah, that choice was sort of the problem. Catra can't really live with it, she's come to find.

Catra from this time *is* the problem. Most, if not all of her self-hatred comes from this point in her life. There is nothing redeemable about this version of herself.

Anyway. This Adora can never find out Catra is here. Adora has, rightfully, given up on her by now. She's busy trying to keep the Alliance together, fending off the Horde and keep her friendship with Glimmer from oxidizing.

Again-all problems that *she* has caused.

"No," Catra shakes her head, "We can't bother Adora with this."

This is her mess to fix.

Are you afraid? Melog asks.

"No," she denies, before remembering how futile it is. "I mean. I can't mess anything up. This Adora can't know that I defected from the Horde or that I...or well, anything about us, really. Or it might change the choices she makes and then the future won't play out the way it's supposed to."

She knew the risks of this mission and she didn't come empty handed. One of the gems in her bag can serve as a mind-erasing agent if absolutely necessary. But Catra would really rather avoid further likening herself to the monster that was Shadow Weaver.

If it really comes down to it, she'll use the stone. She can't afford to mess up her present life more than she already has.

"Besides, she might not even believe me. And it's not like I can fault her for that." It's a cheap excuse, Catra is well-aware.

This is a rather elaborate apology, Melog points out. *Would it not have been enough to speak the truth to your Adora?"*

"No. Adora doesn't need apologies or bullshit explanations," Catra shakes her head. Although it couldn't hurt to apologize, she won't allow herself to return home until this mission is a success. "She needs more than that. They all do."

Melog makes a noise of disagreement, *I think they just need you.*

"Okay well then I *need* to be someone who deserves them," Catra snaps.

Catra tears her eyes away from Adora as the latter heads inside the castle. During the war, Catra never noticed how *tired* Adora looked. How sad. It makes Catra's heart pang a bit. Realistically, she knows that not all of Adora's sadness is not directly her own fault but...enough of it is.

Damn that portal and all of her self-destructive tendencies.

Melog seems to give up on the argument. *We need someone to help us.*

That much is true. She looks around as everyone files inside, except for one member that lingers behind. Stories relayed and offhand comments made in passing connect together and she knows there is someone in the Rebellion who is feeling a little lost on the outskirts right now. A little helpless, too.

Someone a bit more reasonable than she originally gave them credit for.

With a wicked grin, Catra zeroes in on them and knows exactly what she has to do. Maybe this won't be too difficult, after all.

Bow has always proven himself to be a pretty easy target.

One Week Prior

“What are you doing here?” Catra can barely hide the snarl in her voice.

She knows it isn’t a fair question. They have as much right to be here as she does, and this is hardly their first run-in on Bright Moon grounds, but *still*.

She’s already in a bad mood. She woke up late and has been stuck wandering around the stupid gardens here because *all* of her friends have just gone off somewhere. Melog has become fascinated by Swift Wind and is probably spending their morning observing him do something stupid.

“Why, I’m just here to watch and learn,” Double Trouble responds with an airy tone. “I never could quite master the art of grieving. Or--you know, remorse over the loss of genuine human attachment.”

Her eyes narrow into slits, “What is that supposed to mean?”

“Oh,” They blink at her, studying her carefully like they’re trying to puzzle her out, “You don’t know, do you? Truly, I thought this day would be commemorated on all Bright Moon calendars. And surely, with the Queen as your political advisee, I didn’t suspect you would miss it.”

“Miss *what* ?” Catra’s patience for them is wearing thin, and it’s not like she had much of it to begin with.

Not all of the blame falls on DT, though. Catra knows that much. It isn’t their fault that all of her memories of them are rooted in the lowest point of her life. And it isn’t their fault that she can’t stand the sight of them because all she sees are the worst parts of herself reflected right back. The parts she wishes she could just parse out and rid herself of.

“The two-year anniversary of Queen Angella’s death,” They explain as if it’s common knowledge. And, actually, it feels like it *should* be common knowledge. How did Catra not know that was today? She feels the air catch in her lungs as their words register

in her mind. "Or, you know *not*- death. Something about her being stuck in between dimensions, or whatever."

Catra's eyes widen. *The Portal.* She can feel her heart pound in her chest, beating painfully against her ribs as the memories come pouring to the surface. There is a phantom burning sensation up her arm and it takes everything in her not to look down at herself to ensure that *she* is still here. Whole. Not cracked and voided, with pieces of herself breaking away as the world shatters around her.

"Oh my, you look like you've seen a ghost," They croon with a faux-sympathetic smile, "Relax, kitten. It's not like *you* dug the Queen's grave yourself."

But that is exactly what she did. Her jaw snaps shut and her hands curl into fists. She can't tell if DT is saying that just to twist the knife, or they honestly don't *know*.

"And we certainly wouldn't want to look into the fact that your little friends chose to keep this from you, would we?" They look over Catra's shoulder and give a slight nod. Catra whips her body around at break-neck speed to find Adora, Bow and Glimmer approaching from the general direction of where Angella's memorial lies.

There is a somber air about them. Adora and Bow both have an arm over Glimmer's shoulder as they approach.

Fuck. She knows DT must be right. The three of them *have* been acting secretive lately. Adora has been more cagey than usual. And she isn't sure what feels worse, the irrefutable truth that she's caused her friends this pain, or that they've clearly tried to keep it from her.

DT continues to talk, but Catra doesn't hear a word of whatever they have to say. She stalks away from them, consumed by the ugly truth that gnaws at her gut for the rest of the day.

She may criticize Adora for being a terrible actor, but she has always struggled to mask her emotions. All it really takes is just thirty seconds alone with her girlfriend before the inevitable question comes to the surface,

"Catra? Is something wrong?"

Adora is looking at her with worry, blue eyes gleaming with concern as a frown pulls at the bottom of her lips. It's just them in their room, but Catra doesn't need Melog here to know what they would say. What they would encourage her to do.

"Adora," She takes a deep breath, trying not to sound too angry or accusatory, "Are you...are you hiding something from me?"

When questioned, Adora's eyes widen in a way that would be almost comical if Catra didn't feel like such *shit* right now. She starts to get red in the face, sputtering out a response, "I-you? Me-hiding you-something? And-"

Resigned, Catra puts up a hand in a silent request for Adora to stop flailing. She reminds herself that Adora is probably just trying to *protect* her and, even if it isn't warranted, it is not mean-spirited.

"You can't lie Adora, so don't even try," Catra sighs, her words seem to only make Adora *more* panicked. "I know...okay? I know about today. About...Queen Angella."

Weirdly, the tension seems to fade from Adora's body. She stops sputtering, and her face grows still and serious, "Oh. Catra…" Something in her voice even sounds relieved, which Catra doesn't quite understand.

"I just don't know why you guys tried to hide it from me," She frowns, arms crossed and suddenly interested in looking just about anywhere that isn't Adora's face.

"We weren't trying to hide it from you!" Adora is quick to say, placing her hands on Catra's arms, "I swear."

“Then why didn’t you tell me?” Catra asks.

“Oh. Uh, well. It wasn’t on purpose. It’s just that...you never really knew her,” Adora explains. Catra fights the part of herself that wants to snap and call Adora a liar--but she knows her words are true, and she isn’t mad at Adora. She’s mad at herself. “We didn’t think you’d want to go. I mean, all Bow and I did was sort of just, stand there. Glimmer and Micah told us stories about her and we just sort of listened for a bit.”

“Is that really why?” Catra asks, “Or is it because it’s my fault she’s not here?”

Adora reels backwards at the question, “What? Of course not. No one thinks that.”

Catra’s face wobbles. Of course they don’t think it’s her fault. They’re too fucking *good* and haven’t caught on to the fact that she just...isn’t. Maybe she’s better now, but back then? The girl who threw the lever? There is *nothing* good or redeemable about her.

Even if they don’t hate *that* Catra, she most certainly does. A reflection of Shadow Weaver, she was the real monster all along--

“Hey,” Adora’s hands frame her face now, “I’m serious, Catra. No one blames you for what happened. I know...there was a time, where I was angry about everything that happened but we both made mistakes. There was a lot going on…”

Excuses, excuses, excuses. It’s all they are.

But Adora continues trying to reassure her. So selflessly. So *determined* to make Catra feel better, that she just has to go along with it. Smile and nod and let her girlfriend feel like she’s helping.

But at the end of the day, it’s really all just bullshit.

Bow stirs eventually with a heavy groan, eyes blinking open slowly. Once he gets a visual on who the hell has tied him up, his eyes widen comically large and he cries behind the gag in his mouth.

They're in the Whispering Woods and dragging Bow here was *no* picnic for her and Melog, even under the guise of invisibility.

"Morning sleeping beauty," She smirks as he tries to move against his makeshift restraints. She leans down in front of him as he continues yelling at her. "I just want to talk. I'll remove the gag, but you can't yell or scream or I'll have to put it back. Got it?"

Bow nods slowly, eyes still wide with alarm. She pushes the gag down, only for him to immediately yell, "Help! Help!-"

"Ugh," Catra rolls her eyes, throwing a hand over his mouth. "That's on me. I shouldn't have trusted you."

Bow, who she has greatly underestimated, takes it a step further and *licks* her palm. She screeches and yanks her hand back, since when did Arrow Boy fight *dirty* ? Before he can open his mouth to yell again, she shoves the gag back in his mouth.

"Okay! I get it, you don't trust me. You hate me. Blah blah blah," Catra rolls her eyes, "Melog, a little help?"

Melog appears then, tail swaying happily at the sight of Bow. Even if it isn't the Bow they know.

Bow, however, looks very freaked out by their presence and tries to inch backwards as they approach.

"Relax. They're not going to hurt you, dumbass," Catra sighs impatiently. They lick the side of Bow's face before nuzzling it in a sign of affection. She bites back a snicker at how surprised Bow is-perhaps a bit disgusted at a foreign creature licking his face.

Present-Bow loves Melog. That's no secret. She's definitely going to have to use some of the mind-eraser on Bow before leaving,

but that's manageable.

"This is Melog," She says, "And you know who I am, clearly. But I'm not...I'm not the Catra who trapped you guys in the electrical field today."

She mumbles the last part. He looks at her, skeptical. But then he *really* looks at her. The short hair, barely long enough to pull into a small ponytail. The absence of a Force Captain Badge. Then he looks down to Melog, who is now sitting dutifully at her side.

"Come on. You think if I had a magical space cat on my side, I'd be hiding it from you guys?" She snorts, "Melog can do illusions. *And* make us invisible." At her pointed stare, Melog glows a bright, blue hue before disappearing.

"Mmf?" Bow looks at them in disbelief as they reappear.

"I'm from a different timeline. An alternate universe, actually." A bold-faced lie. She is very much from this timeline. But maybe if she can convince him that she isn't, he'll treat her like an anomaly and their current timeline won't need as much fixing once she leaves.

"And I need your help to get back." Another lie. She isn't going back. She just needs him to help her get to Razz.

"Now, let's try this again. If I take off the gag, are you going to scream?" She huffs, impatient. "Seriously. I can do this all day. It's up to you how difficult you want this to be."

When he shakes his head 'no', she removes the gag and cautiously moves backward. She keeps her eye trained on him, still crouching down near the ground and ready to put it back in place.

With the gag removed, it's off to the races. He fires question after question off with rapid speed.

"How am I supposed to know you're telling the truth? If this...Melog can do illusions, how do I know you're *not* the Catra who threw me off of a cliff? And *if* you're really not from this universe, what are you doing here?"

She *is* the Catra who threw him off a cliff. But letting him know that isn't going to do her any favors.

She takes a deep breath, "You know I'm telling the truth because- do I *look* like your Catra? And the fact that Melog is here with me is proof enough. If the Catra you know had that kind of power in her corner, wouldn't it be kind of game over for you guys?" She crosses her arms, looking a bit smug.

He fixes her with a flat, unimpressed look. Right. Now is not the time for bragging. Especially when Catra knows very well how this ends. How she loses to the Rebellion and how she gains more in that loss than in any victory she could possibly claim.

Catra coughs, "Um. Yeah. Anyway. I'm not supposed to be here." That much is the truth at least. "I was trying to...whatever. Doesn't matter. Point is, I ended up here by accident, and I need you to help me."

"Why me?" He asks, eyeing her apprehensively.

"Because I'm not exactly crawling with friends in this universe, am I?" Catra poses with an arched brow, "And you might not know me, but I know *you*, Arrow Boy. I know about your stupid sense of nobility and your duty to helping people."

"Yeah," he scoffs, "I'm dedicated to helping the people of *Etheria* , not the people who have tried to destroy it."

Ouch. She winces at his words, which is all the confirmation he seems to need, "And judging by that reaction... you clearly tried to destroy Etheria in your timeline too. Why should I help you?"

"Isn't one Catra bad enough?" She challenges. She tried the amicable route. If he wants to play dirty, fine. She can *play* dirty.

“You help me get out of here and then I'll be out of your hair. You don’t really want two of me hanging around, do you?”

Bow looks between her and Melog. “Why? You said it yourself, with Melog here you’d ‘win the war’.” He can’t move his hands to make air quotes, but she can hear them in his voice. “So why don’t you go to the Fright Zone and, I don’t know-help yourself win the war?”

Helping herself isn’t really Catra’s strong suit. Running in the complete opposite direction of anything even remotely resembling help is. Or used to be. At least at this time, it was.

He looks nervous-as if his suggestion will actually prompt Catra to go do exactly that.

She just snorts at him. “Because...I don’t want this.” She gestures vaguely to the direction of the Fright Zone. “At least not in my universe.”

How badly she wants to tell him the truth. That this isn’t what their Catra wants either. Not truly.

Even now, all she wants is to run to Adora. To tell her everything and prevent Prime from happening. But she can’t. She can’t mess up this timeline. That was made very clear.

She’s already almost destroyed the universe once. She isn’t willing to tempt fate again.

“Why not?” He questions. Somehow that’s the most annoying question he’s asked yet. Mainly because she can’t answer *why*. “I mean-what changed? How could things be so different where you’re from?”

“They just are!” She snaps, “Look, I dont have the answer to all of life's questions for you. If you’re not going to help me, and nothing I can say will change your mind, then fine. Just say it and I’ll let you go. I don’t have time to waste.”

He looks alarmed at her response. Something about it he was clearly not expecting, she just isn't sure what. "You're...serious about this, aren't you?"

"I can't tell you everything," Catra confesses. "You know. Interdimensional space-time travel code and all that. But...I only left my universe because I wanted to fix things. So I'm doing this, whether or not I have your help."

"What are you trying to fix?" He asks, but she shakes her head.

"Can't say."

"You're not giving me much to work with here," He sighs, "Like, seriously. Do you know how vague this all is? All you've done in this universe is attack and hurt my friends. And now you're here, claiming to be from another universe. But you won't tell me *how* things are different or what you came back here to do. How do you expect me to just trust you?"

"Because we're friends!" She exclaims, earning a warning growl from Melog to keep her voice down. "Where I'm from. We're sort of…" She mumbles the last part, knowing he can't hear her.

"I'm sorry, what was that?"

"We're best friends, alright?" She hisses.

He is appalled by her statement. Silence hangs heavy in the air for a moment too long.

"Yeah. That actually might be the craziest thing you've said so far." He stares at her, unblinking. And damn, that hurts. She kind of forgot how much they hated her. She knows she's completely earned their animosity, but still- it didn't bother her back then. She barely knew Bow's name.

But now that they are friends? Having to go back in time and confront the hurt she's caused *sucks.*

It’s too much, actually. There’s no way her friends don’t hate her now if they hated her so much at this point in her life. Is everyone...just lying to her?

“Wait—Catra? Are you-are those tears?” Bow asks, astonished.

And *no*, they’re not. Not at all. “Screw you. Come on Melog, let’s go.”

Melog jumps over Bow’s legs to stand by her side. She left his trackerpad on him for this reason. Someone will figure out he’s missing and pick up on the signal to locate him. Then he’ll probably tell whoever it is about this weird interaction, they’ll think it over for maybe a day before something inevitably weirder happens.

“Wait!” He calls out. “If...I agree to help you, what is it you need me to do?”

Catra exhales. This is easy enough. Or it should be, for him at least.

“Has Adora ever told you about Madam Razz?” She asks, turning to face him. He looks surprised at the way she mentions Adora. With only ease, no trace of malice whatsoever.

“Uh she may have mentioned her once or twice, nothing too detailed though.”

“Has she ever taken you to meet Razz?” Adora has taken Catra to her a few times to spend the day. Help her bake. Listen to her ramblings. Pretend not to be a little unnerved.

“No, she hasn’t.”

It’s a bit of a relief in the same way it is every time Catra realizes Adora reserves certain things for just the two of them. But now it is a bit inconvenient-all of this would be easier if Bow could just take Catra there himself.

“Right. Thought so. She’s…” Catra is not quite sure how to describe Razz, “she’s someone who is consistent. Across space and time. She helped Mara, the She-Ra before Adora and she was trying to help me. Only problem is I don’t know how to find her. I need you to figure out how to get to her from Adora. Draw me a map, or whatever.”

Bow nods along. “And then what?”

“That’s it.”

“That's it?” He scoffs, “You just need me to help you figure out how to get to an old woman’s house? From Adora?”

Catra reminds herself to be patient, “That about sums it up, yes.”

She bites back a smirk at her words, remembering the feeling of using them against Bow for the first time.

“Feels like there’s gotta be a catch here,” he arches one brow.

“Given the fucked up shit I’ve done here, that makes sense,” she admits, much to his surprise. “But I’m not that person anymore, and I’m not exactly her biggest fan either.”

“If that’s true, then why don’t you just ask Adora yourself?” Bow wonders.

Melog meows proudly, *He’s right.*

“Quiet you,” she commands without any real heat. They walk over to her and nudge her legs, she takes the hint and bends down to pet them with a soft smile. She feels a bit sad, actually. It feels like the emotion has struck her out of nowhere, but Melog must’ve seen it coming before she did.

Bow is studying her intently, waiting for a response.

“I have no right to ask Adora for help,” she speaks low and controlled. Past or present Adora--she’s certainly fucked that up

too. "She has her hands full right now. In this timeline...I mean, I *think* in this timeline she always... hoped I would turn around. Stop fighting for the Horde. Trying to destroy Etheria. You know? And I used that against her all the time. But now, after the portal, she gets it. And that's...good. Smart. Overdue, even. So I can't just go waltzing into her life from a different place and time completely and give her false hope. I- *no*. She needs to view me as the enemy to protect you guys and I can't screw that up."

Catra didn't realize she'd gotten so carried away. Melog headbutts her affectionately, prompting her to look up to Bow. He's looking back at her with a strange look on his face. One she can't quite place.

"What?" She snaps.

"You care," he breathes, both amazed and confused. "About her. And *us* even."

"Yeah, well. I said we were friends, didn't I?" She spits back, certain she'll have to use the failsafe on him before she leaves.

"Showing is different than telling," he informs her.

"Whatever," Catra huffs. "Are you going to help me, or not?"

"*Only* because you're not asking for help to do something life-alteringly dangerous and you definitely are not the Catra we know," he leads before saying, "I'll help you."

"Deal," She flashes him a smile that is all teeth before reaching down and undoing the restraints.

The Night Before

"What you're proposing is *dangerous*. No one has ever successfully traveled back in time before--"

"Yeah, yeah whatever. No sorcerer has cracked the time travel code, I get it," Catra waves him off, "But no other sorcerer is the ruler of Mystacor *and* has his wife trapped in another dimension."

Micah frowns at her, but there is a crack in his stare that tells her all she needs to know.

"I know you have something that can work," Catra prays the desperation in her voice isn't as obvious as she fears, "And I *know* you're too afraid to use it for yourself because you don't want to leave your daughter without a father again. So let me, instead."

If he's alarmed by her dramatic entrance into his study-slamming the doors open and chest heaving with exertion as if she was trying to outrun the devil himself, she wouldn't blame him. In the last two years, they have maybe exchanged all of five sentences to each other and never one-on-one. He had tried to speak with her once or twice, but she always knew where the conversation would end: in either rightfully-placed blame or unearned forgiveness. Neither of which she was willing to confront until this very moment.

"Catra, it's too dangerous. If I wouldn't risk it myself, there is no way I'm allowing you to do the same." Micah's voice is unreasonably stern.

It pisses her off.

"Why do you care?" She snarls at him, "If anything, you should be the one *shoving* me back in time yourself. It's my mess to fix and I'm finally taking responsibility for my actions, just like everyone's been waiting for me to do."

"I care because what's done is done," He tells her calmly, "You can't change the past. It would be foolish to try. You'll risk ruining what you have now. All you can do is-"

"Cut the crap," Catra slams her palms on the table in front of him. It's easier to do this if she's *angry* with herself. There is no room

to wallow in self-pity. "We both know I don't deserve what I have now. I shouldn't be here--"

"Catra," His expression turns to one of worry. "Did something...happen tonight?"

"What? Does everyone just know?" Catra seethes. It's a ridiculous question. Of course everyone *knows*. Adora can't keep a secret, and Catra knows she must've enlisted the help of all of her friends just to plan the stupid date, anyway. They were all probably on standby, waiting to receive some form of good news that ultimately never came.

Micah coughs awkwardly, confirming her suspicions. "I mean, we just assumed...Adora--and you, you would be happy."

"You think I'm that selfish?" She snaps. She's been steadfastly ignoring Melog for this conversation and their wide-eyed stare as they observe the conversation. "You think I can just what, run off into the sunset without a care in the world? You think I don't care about the things I've done? The people I've hurt?"

"No-"

"You think that shit doesn't give me *nightmares?* That I don't close my eyes and see the fucking world fall apart beneath me, and know that I got her stuck there?" Catra continues to rant. "I'm not an idiot. Okay? I know I don't deserve to be...I don't deserve any of this shit."

"I *think* what you need to do is speak with Adora about this," He decides, turning around as if he'll summon her just by calling her name.

"Your wife is gone. Because of me!" She's yelling now, and it's not like Micah exactly needs reminding of this, but she figures this may be the only way to get through to him. "She should be here. And maybe, if I can bring her back...then maybe I'll deserve to be here too."

Micah has a look in his eyes that is far too close to pity, and Catra just can't fucking stand it. He opens his mouth to say something, but she intervenes again.

"So, either you tell me whatever the hell it is you've come up with and we actually have a shot at making this work, or I take your shit and figure it out on my own," She digs her claws into the table for emphasis.

"Nothing I can say will change your mind, will it?" Micah asks, resignation deep in his tone.

"Do you think we'd be here right now if I was the kind of person who openly took advice?" Her response is scathing and self-deprecating. But god, how many times did Adora beg her not to open the Portal in the first place? Even Scorpia offered her a way out more than once. Not to mention how she could've avoided this entire outcome if she had listened to Adora once they were *in* the Portal.

"If you're going to do this, you might as well do it *safely.* " Micah sighs before turning around to look at Melog, "I trust you will be accompanying her?"

They respond with an affirmative rowl.

He explains the gems to her. With a prick of blood: pink quartz will bring her back in time. Sapphire will bring her home. Seraphinite can serve as a memory wipe. Hopefully she won't even need it at all. She debates leaving it behind, but Micah insists-promising that it is only there for the absolute worst-case scenario.

Sort of like a failsafe.

Chapter End Notes

> this will def be shorter than exile/hoax with less found family and more of a catra-character study BUT I couldn't just leave micah out of this entirely, sorry

never was ready

"Ugh, are you kidding me?" Catra groans, battling with the urge to slash her claws across a nearby tree, "It's not that hard!"

This is taking *way* too long. It's the second time Bow has reported back to her that he hasn't been able to get any information from Adora about Razz.

"Yeah well it's not that *easy* either," Bow straightens himself, something determined in his gaze. "Neither of them even listen to me anymore! All they do is argue and all anyone is focused on anymore is the Horde. Because *you* keep attacking and taking our land!"

She's quick to correct him, "Not me."

Not true.

"You know what I mean Catra," Bow crosses his arms and keeps his resolve strong. "Adora says she doesn't have time to go visit Razz and honestly? I agree with her. Now that the Horde is closing in-"

She wants to yell at him and tell him it doesn't *matter* if the Horde is closing in. None of this matters at all. It doesn't matter how much land they take now, the Horde will eventually fall.

"And *now* Glimmer has some weird thing going on with Shadow Weaver," Bow's voice cuts back in and she immediately bristles.

Shadow Weaver. Catra's relationship with grief may be complicated but it's clear enough for her to know she has little interest in seeing that soul-sucking bitch again.

She has no interest in anything here, actually. Her skin itches and she grows more and more impatient with each second that they're still stuck here. She's dredged up some memories that she'd rather stay long buried and figures it's only a matter of a few days

before Salineas falls. Before Scorpia officially has enough of her shit and leaves.

"You're a bad friend."

Yeah. Scorpia pretty much nailed that one on the head.

Melog looks up at her curiously. They can't read her thoughts, but they are likely feeling her discomfort and general irritation.

Maybe Catra was a shit friend to Scorpia, but it's not like she's faring much better now with Bow, either. He doesn't know how everything changes in the future and, as a result, doesn't exactly have warm or fuzzy feelings for Catra. And it's not like she's exactly fond of his stupid past self, either.

They've reached a weird stalemate.

"You told me you were going to help me." Catra reminds him, eyes narrowed as anger flares in her chest, "Are you going back on your word?"

"Did you listen to anything I just said?" Bow asks, "We don't have time-"

"Then make time!" Catra snaps, "I know for a fact you guys are not strictly 'all work and no play'. Maybe stop fucking around for two minutes and then I'll be out of your hair."

"Adora doesn't want to go," He repeats and she can sense the surmounting frustration in his tone.

"Then tell her it's important! It's for some mission, or, or whatever."

"I'm not going to lie to her! She's been dealing with enough, between Glimmer and Angella and now Shadow Weaver," Bow refuses.

"Ugh!" She groans, temper flaring. "Seriously-"

Melog jumps to their feet and nudges against her leg. *He is not being difficult on purpose*, they inform her.

"I know that!" She hisses, turning her glare down towards them. It's a brief spark of anger and once it leaves she finds herself feeling a bit deflated. Her ears pin back and her shoulders droop. "I know." Her voice is much softer the second time around.

She doesn't want him to lie to Adora. She knows Adora is hurting enough as it is. It may have taken some time, but Catra sees now how badly Adora was hurt after the Portal. Not just because of Angella, but because of Catra*, too*.

Adora may have left her first, but Catra is the one who burnt any bridge that remained between them.

And if that wasn't bad enough, Catra had even hired DT to sabotage Adora's friendship with Glimmer and that bomb was set to explode any day now.

Catra can't be here for that. Can't be here and see Shadow Weaver. Or watch Scorpia defect and join the Alliance. Or witness just how badly her actions have hurt Adora.

She takes a deep inhale to steady herself.

"Look...I get it, okay? I know this isn't easy. If your... *universe* is anything like mine…" She is careful with her words, striving to keep up with her own web of lies. "Then I know how much everything...sucks right now."

Bow looks at her curiously, like he's trying to determine whether or not this offer of empathy is some sort of trap.

With great hesitation, he takes the risk.

"It's like they just...don't even listen anymore. No matter what I say or do, I can't get them to stop arguing with each other. We used to be best friends and that used to *mean* something. But now…"

Catra crosses her arms, raising her eyesbrows in gentle encouragement.

"It's not enough. *I* feel like I'm not enough," Bow admits begrudgingly, averting his stare to the ground.

Melog takes the opportunity to stroll over to him, delighting when Bow reaches down to pet them.

Swallowing her reflexive desire to deflect the tension by minimizing his feelings through a joke or scathing remark, Catra takes another deep breath. She can't give him advice or tell him how to fast track this debacle, even if she sort of wants to. She can't risk messing up the future.

"I used to feel like that, too." She tells him, throat tight. He snaps his gaze back onto her, eyes wide. "Adora left the Horde here too, didn't she?" When he nods, she continues, "I always just...sort of thought that...maybe there was a way where I could've gotten her to stay. If I was, y'know, a better friend. Or cadet, or didn't get us into trouble as much."

"Adora never told us much about you. Or your time together in the Horde," Bow tells her, his voice a bit mystified.

"Yeah well, not much good to tell," Catra laughs bitterly. She already knew that much, but the confirmation doesn't feel incredible. "And I always thought that if she saw how the Horde was winning or how *I* was winning, more specifically...she might come back."

"But she didn't. Did she?" Bow asks, but there is no trace of smugness or victory in his tone.

"No. She didn't. And I thought I wasn't enough. I let myself believe that so much that it took me to some real shitty places," She cackles dryly again. "But you wanna know a secret?"

Wearily, Bow nods, hand slowing where he's been petting Melog.

“Not being enough isn’t the problem--and it isn’t *our* problem,” Catra explains, “If Glimmer and Adora aren’t listening to you, it’s not because you should be doing something else or something *more*. They’re the ones who need to be better friends and communicate more, yeah? We don’t have to meet some unspoken bar just to be heard.”

Bow just stares at her for a second, eyes skeptical. But she’s staunch in this belief and she won’t let the same insecurities over feeling too vulnerable come crawling back up her spine.

She wishes she had known this years ago. Before Adora found the sword. And she wishes she could’ve wrapped her head around the fact that other people’s actions aren't a reflection of her own worth.

The heartache and turmoil she could have spared herself if only she had just realized Shadow Weaver was just *shitty*. That there wasn’t anything she could’ve done to make the sorceress any less shitty. Same goes for Hordak.

Adora is more complicated. They’ve both made mistakes. Adora’s are far more manageable and it may not always be easy, but they’ve made substantial progress in the last few years.

As for her own mistakes? Catra knows they lie comfortably under the label of unforgivable.

Bow clears his throat and she is suddenly *very* aware that she’s gotten lost in her own thought.

“I never thought of it that way I guess,” Bow says, voice soft and contemplative. He doesn’t look at her with the same regard as he has the last few times they’ve interacted; he looks like he trusts her. Believes her story, even if it’s just a little bit.

She shrugs back at him, “Just something to think about.”

There is another beat of silence before he asks, “Are you—were you always like this...before, too? In your world?”

Catra blinks at him. Trying to think of the right thing to say, needing to correctly anticipate what he might do with information. If he thinks there is something good, something redeemable about the Catra of his present he will only make the same mistakes as Adora already has.

It turns out that, for once, the truth is easier:

"No." Her voice is rougher than she really intends for it to be. "Took a long time to get here. I was really fucked up. And I've *seen* this world's Catra. So don't...don't sit there and hope that one day she'll just wake up like this. She's your enemy and that's just how it is. There's nothing beyond that."

She needs him to hate her almost as much as she hates herself here.

He stands up from petting Melog, scratches his head awkwardly and looks up at her. His face has changed again, like he isn't so sure what to believe.

"If you say so," he sighs.

The air has turned awkward again.

"Just—find a way to get to Razz, alright?" Catra implores.

"I will," he promises with a determined cadence in his voice. He has the same resolute look that's always reminded her of Adora. She's seen it more than once in her own time.

The smile she gives him in return is small but authentic.

He turns to walk away, but not without first looking over his shoulder and saying "And...um. Thanks. It was nice to…talk." A breathless laugh punches out of him, "Sorry. It's just—this is so weird."

She returns it with a smirk and says, "Trust me, I know."

The Night Before

"You're acting weird," Catra tells Adora, matter-of-factly.

To Catra's credit, Adora responds to the accusation by turning to face her so quickly that she misses a step and starts hurtling towards the bottom of the staircase.

Catra is quick enough to grab hold of her arms and prevent her from falling all the way down. They wind up very closely pulled together, their bodies just inches apart as Adora catches her breath. Adora looks up to her, face red with embarrassment, while Catra keeps her own blasé.

She is attempting to fight off her own worry at Adora's anxiety, fearful of what it could mean. She sends her girlfriend a smirk and says, "Falling for me, princess? Don't need to be so obvious about it."

Adora lets out a laugh before wrinkling her nose, "Ha. That was cheesy."

"Come on, that would've sent you *reeling* at Frosta's Princess Prom," Catra points out with a hint of arrogance.

"Maybe that's true," Adora rights herself and rolls her shoulders back, "But I kinda prefer how things are now."

"Hm," Catra acknowledges the sentiment, holding out her arm for Adora to lace hers through. At the very least, this will make Adora falling a bit less likely.

"What about you?" Adora asks as they continue down the staircase, "Do you...like things how things are now?"

Adora is nervous, that much is painfully obvious. Her words are shaky and her voice is breathy, trembling a bit at the end. The flush has yet to completely fade from her face.

“How things are now?” Catra echoes, “With my girlfriend, the great and mighty She-Ra, acting like a total weirdo and almost getting her ass handed to her by a flight of stairs?”

“Hey! It’s-it’s this *dress*,” Adora complains, running her hand over her midsection to smooth out the wrinkles that aren’t even there. It is most certainly *not* the dress. It’s a short, v-neck satin royal blue dress that cuts off right above her knee. There is no way for her to really trip over it, however large her capacity for clumsiness may be.

But Catra knows her girlfriend well enough by now. She knows Adora *likes* wearing dresses, but can feel a bit awkward or uncomfortable in them. It’s still hard for Adora to do things simply because she wants to do them and she fights the need to rationalize every choice she makes.

They’re working on it.

“Don’t blame the dress,” Catra tells her in a low, sultry tone, “You look gorgeous, by the way.”

And *oh* does Adora light up at that. Her face only reddens more, eyes shining as she straightens her posture and leans into a bit of confidence. “Oh-you think so?”

“I do,” Catra confirms when they reach the bottom step. She turns to face Adora fully, reaching up to tuck a strand of hair behind her ear. Adora’s been wearing it in a half-up style more and more lately, finally giving the tried and true ponytail a bit of a rest. “*Maybe* if we ditch this dinner, I can prove it to you.”

Catra is wearing a simple white button up shirt and a pair of black dress pants, her own hair has grown just long enough to make its way to a small ponytail in the back of her head.

“We can’t,” Adora chides, despite the fact that Catra could tell she was very much *considering it*.

“Glimmer would get over it,” Catra rolls her eyes, but accepts her fate as Adora tugs her closer to one of the doors to the castle’s terrace.

Before she opens the door, she takes a steadying breath and Catra is reminded of how *off* Adora has been lately. She furrows her brow, biting her bottom lip in contemplation. This still feels like it has to be about Angella somehow. Catra can’t quite get that off of her mind.

She just feels so...guilty. Largely, she avoids thinking about the former Queen and for this exact reason. Now she can’t get her brain to stop fixating on Angella and, by consequence, all of her worst mistakes.

What right does she have to be in the very castle that Angella used to rule in?

The answer is simple; she has *no* right. The only variable she hasn’t quite figured out is when everyone else will catch on to that fact.

Catra is pulled from her thoughts when Adora opens the doors and reveals a single table, clothed in white and set for two. There is a candle in the center, but Catra isn’t sure they even need it with how brightly the moon is shining above them.

“Adora?” Catra calls out, voice confused, “What is this? Where is everyone else?”

Adora smiles back at her nervously, “They’re not coming. I wanted to do something with...just the two of us. Is that okay?”

Okay? *Okay.* Understatement of the century, just about. Catra certainly isn’t about to complain about time alone with her girlfriend.

Catra still isn’t sure what's going on, or if this is why Adora has been acting so weird lately, but her girlfriend rambles on to say, “I was thinking we could have dinner, and then-I don’t know, we can

look at the stars? I brought a blanket--but if you don't want to, that's totally okay!"

Catra shoves her own nerves aside.

"Adora, stop. It's perfect, okay?"

Adora gives her a weary smile, "Really? Are you sure? Because-"

"*Yes* I'm sure I don't have a problem with my girlfriend doing something romantic for me," Catra rolls her eyes, "Although I gotta admit…" she looks around the set up with mock contemplation, "This *is* pretty cheesy."

"Hey!" Adora squawks out with indignation.

"What? You can dish it but you can't take it?" Catra laughs, bumping their shoulders together.

"Oh I can take it," Adora huffs, face turning red when Catra laughs even harder, " *No* -you know I didn't mean it like that!"

Their familiar, playful banter cuts all of the lingering tension in the air. Whatever nerves Adora has been exuding dissipate as she attempts to stifle her laughter and moves to grab Catra.

But Catra evades her grasp with ease, giggling as she pulls just beyond Adora's reach.

True to his word, Bow shows up with a map just a few hours later.

"Adora drew this?" She asks, unable to keep the fond smile on her face at bay.

"Yeah, she was in a bit of a hurry," Bow says sheepishly. Catra studies him for a second and considers how it played out; if he was brushed off and had to *push* Adora for it. If he was insistent

just for the sake of getting Catra off of his back or if her words actually had an impact on him.

"Thanks," she coughs to cover up the edge in her voice. It's chicken scratch, barely legible to anyone who hasn't grown up with the messy scrawl that is distinctly Adora's.

"So it's usable? You can read it, right?" He asks, hopeful. When she nods in affirmation, he breathes out a sigh of relief. "Thank god, that was like, the best I could get from her."

Catra scoffs but her eyes are affectionate, "Typical Adora. Can't slow down long enough on a good day to even write her name out fully. Do you know how many letters I've gotten from 'Ador'? Like a-door? Or just a- *doo* ? Because five whole letters was too much to write?"

It's been less than a day, but damn does Catra miss her. It's kind of stupid, really, how a single poorly drawn map can get her heart tangled up in knots.

When she looks up at him, he has a curious look on his face. "What are you looking at?"

"Nothing!" He denies hastily, "It's just-I forget you two are...friends, somehow."

Friends, somehow.

He's got every right to say it, but it still hurts to hear.

"Yeah, well, we are in my universe, so..." And more, actually. But that information would likely melt his brain.

She rolls the map and shoves it into her backpack, eyes lingering on the sapphire for just a moment too long. This whole nightmare could be over right now if she really wanted it to be.

The temptation is surely there. The urge to return to the time where the concept of goodwill between her and Adora isn't so

hard to grasp.

We can return home anytime, Melog reminds her with a gentle nudge to her leg.

It is comforting to know. To have the verification that she isn't *stuck* here, not completely.

Stuck or not stuck, returning home right now would be selfish.The future Bright Moon is only home to her because everyone is too naive; they have not yet realized she doesn't deserve to call it home. She has to make herself someone who deserves to go back home.

Even if it hurts. *Especially* if it hurts.

"Right, I know, I'm sorry," Bow says. "Is it weird I just...sort of wish it was you in our universe? It's just that-you seem like you care a lot. And you're a good friend to Adora…"

"No," She shakes her head, mouth in a thin line, "It's not weird."

She wishes for it too. Wishes she could go back in time knowing what she knows now. *Being* who she is now. Maybe she's still got a long way to go, but at least she wouldn't make the same mistakes.

"It would just make things a lot easier," Bow continues to explain, "I mean, if we knew this is who you really are? We could work together, somehow--"

"Work together?" She scoffs, "Why the hell would you want to do that? After the whole-destroy the world thing?"

"People make mistakes," Bow shrugs, "And maybe we made one by not--I don't know, recruiting you, or whatever it is we did in your universe. Obviously we did something differently if you're on our side there. Things had to have turned out better."

“Yeah, well,” Catra doesn’t know what to say. “Too late now. Just keep doing whatever the hell it is you idiots do.”

She turns away from him and nearly sprints out to the tree line before he can respond. In her hasty departure, she does not notice the pair of eyes that have been staring at them, watching with great interest.

“Catra, dearie!” Razz exclaims with a wide-toothed grin. “You’re here!”

Finding Razz’s home was not that difficult, Catra continues to prove herself to be fluent in the language of Adora whether it be written or verbal.

“You know me?” Catra reels back from the older woman as she opens the door with a burst of enthusiasm.

Razz recognizing her falls in line with her suspicions about the older woman not bending to the laws of space or time, but is still a bit jarring.

“Of course I do,” Razz ushers her inside, “Come in, come in.”

Catra follows her into the small cottage, looking around with weary eyes. Everything looks exactly the same as it had when Catra visited her once with Adora.

“You’re much too early,” Razz informs her, her tone chiding. “Adora and Mara, they always run late. But you, my dearie, are too early.”

“Just the opposite, actually.” Catra grumbles,“Look. I-”

“This is not your time,” Razz tells her, hand on her hip and slight shake of her staff.

“I know! I have to go back, but I already used the quartz and now-”

“You must go back,” Razz agrees, “Your Adora is looking for you! You left her waiting-”

“No, not back home,” Catra corrects, eyeing Melog wearily as they poke around Razz’s kitchen area. “I need to go back *further*. That’s why I need your help.”

“Help? Oh dearie, I can’t help,” Razz frowns at her.

“Can’t or *won’t* ?” Catra grits.

Razz shakes her head, “No one can help you now. Only you can help yourself.”

"I can’t time travel! I don’t know magic or any of that shit,” Catra fights back as Razz simply clicks her tongue in disapproval.

“Then how did you wind up here?”

“Micah gave me these crystals but I can only use them *once* and it was supposed to send me back to the Portal so I could get Angella but something went wrong and now I’m *stuck* here!”

“Nothing went wrong,” Razz dismisses her, “You are here because here is where you need to be.”

“Okay but you *just* told me I need to be back in my time,” Catra slaps her hand across her forehead, fending off her frustration.

“You have not accepted her,” Razz tsks, “That’s why you’re here.”

“Her who?” Catra asks, paling at the realization that Razz must somehow *know*, “Adora?”

“Not Adora!” Razz says a bit louder, impatient as if Catra doesn’t get *it* but Catra is fairly certain Razz is the one who doesn’t understand. “Haven’t you thanked her yet?”

Catra takes a deep breath and pinches the bridge of her nose, “No. Because I don’t know *who* you’re talking about.”

"Yourself, dearie," Razz responds.

Frustration snaps through Catra at her answer.

"Myself? What are you talking about?"

What ring of Perfuma's self-love hell is this?

"You know her," Razz says, "But you do not like her very much."

Catra narrows her eyes. She's not liking this conversation.

"What do you want me to do? Pat myself on the back for being a self-destructive asshole and pushing away anyone who tried to give a shit about me? I'm not here for that, I'm here for Angella!"

"Be *respectful*. She was very protective of you," Razz shakes her head, "You would not be here if it weren't for her."

"Yeah, glad we can agree on that one," Catra snaps. "I wouldn't be here if she didn't fuck everything up. I'd be back *home* with Adora-"

"Poor child," Razz says and Catra doesn't even have the heart to be offended by the belittling term because Razz actually looks *sad.* "Don't you remember what it's like to be her?"

Catra fights back a snarl at the words, "Obviously*!* But this isn't about me--or her, fuck, whatever! This is about--"

"Your future dearie," Razz finishes for her. It wasn't directly what Catra was going to say, but she supposes it adds up regardless. She can't get her future until she gets Angella back.

"Yes," Catra resigns with a sigh, "My future. Can you help me get that, or not?"

"I already told you!" Razz scolds, "Only *you* can help yourself. But I will tell you this, dearie, the Queen is not the solution to your problems."

Some of the kitchenware that Melog had been aimlessly inspecting tumbles over at Razz's words. The fur rises along their spine as everything comes crashing down.

"Ugh," Catra clenches her fist. This has been a gargantuan waste of time. "You don't *get* it, Razz. Activating the portal is the reason why Angella isn't here--of all the shit I've done, that's like the *one* thing I can't fix. I have to fix it or-or else...I can't go back. Not empty handed."

Maybe that's selfish of her. She's too much of a coward to look Glimmer in the eye, knowing how much she's taken from her. Can't face Micah after she promised to bring Angella back. And there's no way in hell she can even so much as *look* at Adora without having saved Angella. Not after last night..

"You have a long way to go," Razz sighs.

Catra might actually agree with that statement, if only she knew what direction Razz is referring to.

The Night Before

Catra isn't entirely sure what prompted all of this—the dinner or the stargazing, but she is more than content to listen to Adora rattle off information about the stars in the sky. The air between is buzzing with some unnameable current, reminiscent of running down the hallways of the Fright Zone and sneaking out of their bunks late at night. Always tugging and pulling each other along.

And now that they are dancing—which is to say, holding each other close and swaying ever so slightly to the sound of crickets off in the distance, Catra can't help but smile from where her head rests on Adora's shoulder.

In moments like these where there is easy silence and comfort in being in each other's presence, the outside world does not exist to Catra. There is no Glimmer or Bow; no painful reminders of the past.

Hell, there is no *them* outside of this moment either. Catra does not feel the ghosts of her past self pulling at the dredges of her mind, burning in the back of her brain or pulling in the veins under her skin. There is no pit of self loathing churning in her stomach.

But then- *then*, it all comes crashing down.

Adora pulls away and suddenly it's like the peace between them has been sucked out of the air. The air feels thinner, tighter somehow, when Adora slides her hands down Catra's arms and hands until their fingers interlock.

"Catra," Adora exhales with a shaky breath, a nervous smile tugging at her lips. "I…"

She trails off, clearly searching for the right words to say. But Catra is still reeling from the sudden shift in demeanor. Why does everything feel so serious and potent right now? Like one slight misstep and some ominous threat will come crashing down around them.

Unless...unless the misstep has already happened.

"Adora, what's wrong?" Catra frowns, no longer able to fend off the surmounting dread within.

Maybe Catra was wrong. Maybe not everyone is as blind to her glaring faults as she thought. Maybe the anniversary of Angella's not-death death was all the reminder she needed.

Catra can't think of any other reason why Adora would go through all of this effort, put together a perfect night for just the two of them, if not to say goodbye in some capacity. To let her down easy as she ends their relationship.

Of course this is not easy, and all Adora has done is lead her into a false sense of security, but Catra knows that was likely not her intention. Adora doesn't try to hurt people. Adora is good.

Not like *her*.

That's probably why they don't work, why they're here right now, teetering on the precipice that has formed in anticipation of the words forming on Adora's tongue.

"Nothing's wrong!" Adora blurts out with shaky hands causing Catra to jerk back slightly, "Uh-sorry. Nothing's wrong. I'm just nervous."

No shit. Adora being nervous is making *her* nervous.

Maybe she's just worried about how Catra will react, which is a valid fear--given all that happened after Adora left the first time.

"Seriously, whatever it is, I can take it," Catra manages to say. It'll hurt like a bitch, that much is inevitable, but then at least the truth is out there. All of her shadows will be seen and she will no longer feel like she's getting away with something every time she so much as breathes Bright Moon air. "I won't like, try to destroy the planet or anything like that."

"It's nothing bad! I mean, at least-hope not. Everyone told me it wouldn't be a bad thing," Adora insists.

"Everyone?" Everyone would find out eventually, but knowing that this has been planned out, that Adora has consulted all of their friends and this has been some premeditated decision-

"No, not like that," Adora is quick to correct, "I just-I wanted to make sure I did this right."

Did this right? Catra wrinkles her nose. She just needs Adora to get this over with. And if any of their friends knew Catra even a little bit, they wouldn't have suggested this long winded approach to inescapable heartbreak.

"And what is it that you're doing?" Catra asks in an attempt to expedite the conversation.

“Right--I, sorry. No more getting side tracked,” Adora looks at her with schooled determination. Despite the severity of the moment and the impending doom, Catra’s heart beats fondly in her chest at the sight. “I had this whole speech and everything but-”

Adora being nervous must mean there is a part of her that doesn’t want this either. Maybe that should feel validating, but it doesn’t.

“Adora. No fancy speech or anything, alright? Can you just...say whatever it is?” Catra’s voice is pleading and she feels vulnerable but *fuck it*. What does being vulnerable matter now if the floor is just going to be ripped out from under her regardless?

“Had a feeling you might say that,” Adora laughs a little and the tension seems to ease from her body just a bit.

She pulls one hand away to search for something in her dress pocket. Catra keeps her eyes sharp on Adora as she fishes around, still a bit frazzled.

“So, you know how you hate my jacket?” Adora says casually.

Another drastic turn in the conversation that leaves Catra winded. She really isn’t certain what is happening at this point. But if this whole thing is about that *stupid*, offensive jacket--

“I should’ve shredded it when I had the chance,” Catra mutters.

Adora laughs again, bright and airy, “Yeah, well. It’s not the only thing I kept from the Horde, actually.”

She pulls her hand out of her pocket, revealing a familiar gold pin. Her Force Captain badge. In confusion, Catra reels back a bit and blinks down at the item, gleaming in the moonlight.

“Okay, so you know how Spinnerella and Netossa have--oh, wait, right. I’m supposed to kneel,” Adora corrects herself. Before Catra can even ask why the hell she’s getting down on one knee and looking up at her with shining and hopeful eyes she continues,

“There’s this tradition in Etheria, that we never learned about in the Horde--”

All of Catra’s fears come crashing to a complete halt. But the consequence with a stop of such force is that she has gained enough momentum to still send herself hurling towards the edge.

She cuts Adora off, “Are you-are you *proposing* ?” Her voice is thin and she feels like her next breath of air does not come without a gasp.

“Trying to, at least,” Adora flashes her a smile, barely covering her own nervous laugh.

This is the opposite of what Catra was fearing. Her worries about getting *dumped* today couldn’t be further from what is actually happening right now. And somehow…

This

is

worse.

Adora is speaking. She has been for a bit, decidedly launching into her speech after all, but Catra can only hear bits and pieces through the white noise that's ringing in her ears. “...What I’m trying to say is that...Through everything we’ve been through together and apart, we’ve always had a home with each other. This doesn’t even feel, you know, that big or anything because--well, it’s always been the two of us. Right?”

‘That big’. Catra can feel the throngs of panic clawing at her throat and it’s not even *that big* to Adora. Of course it’s not that big to Adora; of course this is just the natural progression for her. Because Adora doesn’t catastrophize, Adora *hopes*.

“...We don’t *have* to do this either. I just...maybe I got a little caught up in thinking about the future. But there’s really no future

where I don't see it being you and I," Adora continues, "I just thought-why not make it official?"

The future. Adora's right. They don't have to do this. *This* isn't the problem. The badge in her hand isn't the issue, and neither is the question on the tip of her tongue. Catra could say no, they could wind up *never* getting married and that wouldn't change how Adora feels. Or thinks. Or *plans*.

Because Adora just knows that they'll be together. Without a doubt in her mind. Any way they proceed from here is fine by her, so long as they do it together.

But that is the crux of the problem at hand. Catra isn't sure if she even deserves the present she has with Adora now. Nevermind a *future*.

How does Adora not see that? How does Adora not see *her?* Adora or any of their friends, really. In what universe does Catra get to roam around the castle that belongs to the queen she *eliminated,* inadvertently or not, and plan her own future? Angella never even got to see Micah had been alive this whole time. Catra stole that from her, robbed her of a future where she could be with her family--and now she's supposed to just ignore that fact? Pretend that she isn't entirely unworthy of everything she has now?

A rush of cold sweeps through her as she looks at Adora-her own mouth agape as she remembers the moments after the Portal. When Adora had looked at her with frigid blue eyes and mouth in a tight line, after Catra had hurled past the point of no return.

"Catra? Are you okay?" Adora asks, prompting Catra to realize that she hasn't said anything at all.

No. She's far from it. She doesn't deserve this. *That* Adora knew it; she must've just forgotten somehow. She's not okay and she doesn't deserve this and it doesn't even matter if she *wants* this because she doesn't deserve it at all-

Adora grips her hand tighter in a way that has provided comfort so many times, Catra doesn't *deserve it*. Doesn't deserve Adora or a future with her.

Unless…

Catra knows she can't right all of her wrongs; there simply isn't enough time in the world. *But* if she can fix her greatest mistake, undo the falling into the point of no return, maybe she'll be someone who is deserving.

But she doesn't say that. Doesn't say anything. She just drops Adora's hand and runs. Leaving Adora waiting out on the terrace for a response that ultimately never comes.

She starts running far away from where Adora is calling after her, back into the hallway, past where Melog is laying in wait, only stumbles once in her climb up the stairs and doesn't stop running until she reaches Micah's study.

While Catra is gone, the Alliance not only realizes that there has been a spy among them, but that they've lost Salineas amongst the chaos. And just when Bow thinks things can't possibly get any worse, Glimmer begins cross-examining DT.

"Oh please. Maybe my performance didn't have you fooled, but let's not pretend I'm the only one taking orders from Kitten commander," they say, grinning wickedly.

The issue is that Bow has come to view the two Catra's as so entirely different that they aren't really interchangeable. So DT's comment doesn't resonate with him, not at first. Not until they transform themselves into the other-Catra, and say,

"Isn't that right, Arrow Boy?"

"Please," Glimmer snorts. "The jig is up. Game over. You lost. Don't go dragging Bow into this."

And *oh god no*. He should have known they were being watched. It was too good to be true, it was going too well. He'd managed to get the map to Catra with little resistance and other-Catra was actually...kind of nice.

"Yeah, right. Bow would never listen to Catra," Adora backs him up, tone resolute. "Besides you don't even-that's not even, you don't even know what she looks like. Obviously."

"Oh really?" DT asks, still as Catra, "Then where have you been sneaking off to, Bow? What's been calling you into the Whispering Woods late, late at night?"

Adora and Glimmer look to him then, faces pinched in confusion.

"I-um. Er. Well-it's. Uh, complicated?" While that may be true, it is sputtered lamely.

"And what about the map you gave me, Bow? What's that all about?" DT asks deviously, stepping closer to the bounds of the rune Glimmer has drawn around them.

"Wait a minute," Adora stops, "Are they-is this true?"

"Have you been *hanging out* with Catra?" Glimmer turns to him, face stretching in horror the longer Bow goes without denying it.

"It's not like that," Bow tries to say quickly, but Adora talks over him.

"You had me draw a map to Madam Razz's to *give to her* ?" Adora demands, "The person who's been trying to kill us?"

"It's not her!" Bow tries to explain, but the truth is even more difficult to believe than any lie he could come up with.

Catra isn't sure why Bow has set his flare arrow off. She didn't really plan on meeting with him again, but maybe it'll be useful to have someone else to bounce ideas off of. Melog has been largely

unhelpful, with pointed stares and meaningful silence to fill the space between them. She guesses her next move is to probably head to Mystacor. See if she can get Casta to come up with something even as half as useful as her brother had.

She's so caught up in planning the logistics of her next move and so annoyed at how Razz has proven to be no help at all, that she doesn't realize how foolishly she's allowed herself to trust the version of her best friend who doesn't trust her at all.

Really, she shouldn't feel as heart broken as she does that the whole thing winds up being a trap.

She arrives at their meeting place, confused and irritated, only to walk right into an ambush. Glimmer ambushes her and Melog, tackling and teleporting them into the castle where an entrapment rune awaits them.

She'd almost forgotten how nauseating teleporting can be. Especially when Glimmer isn't holding any punches this time. It takes her a moment to gain her bearings, looking up at finding Bow on the other side of the rune, looking guilty.

"You!" She seethes, "Are you *kidding* me? What exactly are you playing at, here? We had a deal-"

"Catra?" The voice that calls out to her is familiar. *Too* familiar. Catra spins toward it, eyes wide with shock because there is *Adora*. Past Adora.

The one person who was *not* supposed to see her--and how the fuck is she supposed to fix this now?

you won't remember

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Isn’t this exactly what Catra had wanted?

When the Adora from her time had gotten down on one knee to propose a future together - looking up to her with bright, hopeful eyes, didn’t she *wish* it had been this Adora instead? The one hardened with war and fresh memories of the pain Catra had caused; the one who looked at her and turned her stare cold because she *knew* the monster Catra become?

Time had worn Adora’s memory down, perhaps even softened her in the slightest - that’s how Catra had managed to convince Adora that she actually wanted a life with her.

Maybe it was the fact that Catra had saved Glimmer. That had been her opening, the tiniest crack in the door that could let her back into Adora’s life. The strife and struggle surrounding the threat of imminent doom under Prime’s reign then allowed her to slip under the radar long enough to *stay* .

And Adora can tell her all she wants that she never hated her; maybe Adora truly believes that; maybe someone like Adora is too good to carry something as vile as hatred in her heart. But Catra knows that, at least at this point in their lives, Adora had *seen* her--flaws, fuck-ups and all.

This Adora knows the monster that everyone else has forgotten, and there is something *freeing* about that.

Except...Adora isn’t looking at her like that right now. Catra’s been waiting for the shock and confusion to wear off, but it’s been several long moments of uninterrupted gaping.

Adora looks like her world has been thoroughly rocked while Catra feels like she's seen a ghost. Her mind races, trying to muster up some damage control tactics. But-

"Adora," Her name is out of Catra's mouth before she has a chance to stop it. With just her name spoken, Adora shifts entirely. Her mouth snaps shut, eyes widen in surprise and she shifts backwards. It takes Catra a moment to understand why; it is the softness in her tone. The absence of any contempt. Natural, easy, familiar. It is commonplace between the two of them now, but Catra knows at this time it had been years since Adora heard Catra say her name like that. Like it wasn't a curse, something abhorrent.

"I--what? What's going on?" Adora looks from Bow to Catra with confusion.

Bow who, unlike Catra, is very much *not* in an entrapment rune. He must've sold her out like the annoying--

Catra takes a breath, closing her eyes for a moment before saying, "Look, I don't know what Bow has told you-"

"Does it matter?" Glimmer asks, looking incredibly miffed, "It's not like he can be trusted!"

"Relax Glimmer," Catra shakes her head, "He wasn't helping me because he wanted to. He didn't *willingly* betray you."

Glimmer looks surprised. Catra fights the urge to roll her eyes. They're so obsessed with each other in the present, it's hard to believe Glimmer could ever doubt him or his loyalty. But that's not what Glimmer is so surprised about, apparently. "You-you just called me Glimmer."

"Weird, isn't it?" Bow looks at her with hopeful eyes. Despite betraying Catra, he must still be in trouble with his friends because Glimmer only narrows her eyes at him in response.

“Yes,” Catra seethes, much preferring to look over at Glimmer and Bow than at Adora, who’s gaze she can feel burning into the back of her head,. “Because I’m *not* the Catra you know.”

“I don’t believe you,” Glimmer huffs. Not only is that stupid of her, but it’s fucking irritating as well because she hasn’t even *listened* to what Catra is trying to say.

This whole thing is for *her* mother anyway, so even though Glimmer has zero way of knowing that and has almost as much right as Adora to absolutely hate her, Catra snaps:

“Fine, don’t believe me. I don’t care.”

Melog lets out a noise of discontentment, *If they don’t believe you, they won’t let you go.*

Fair point, but Catra isn’t sure what she’s supposed to do right now, anyway. She crosses her arms and looks down at them, but they look up at her, determined and sway their tail.

Adora already knows you’re here , they inform her as if Catra isn’t already hyper aware of that fact, *perhaps she can help us now.*

“No, no way,” Catra grits her teeth. Melog may have a point, any reasoning she had for not wanting to involve Adora is thoroughly swept out of the window now, but this *still* isn’t her mess to fix.

They tilt their head to the side in question, but are interrupted by Glimmer, “Everyone *hold up* . You get caught on Bright Moon grounds and expect us to believe some giant cover up that you’re not *Catra* and this is what--your pet, whatever?”

Catra snarls, “Their name is Melog and they’re *not* a pet. And I *am* Catra but I’m not the Catra you know.”

Maybe if she says it enough, it can become true. She really can cut out the worst part of herself and finally move on.

“And I didn’t get caught either - you set me up because *you* ,” She turns her attention to Bow, “Sold me out for some reason.”

“I didn’t sell you out! I told them to leave you alone-”

“You’re a *traitor* ,” Glimmer interjects, “Why should we listen to you? You never would’ve told us that you were working with the enemy!”

“Seriously?” Bow asks. There is a deep intonation in his voice, reflecting his hurt. “After everything I’ve done for you guys, you really believe I’d just betray you like that? I stood by your side--both of your sides, through *everything.* Even though you guys hardly ever listen to me anymore because you’re so caught up in your own opinions!”

A silence falls across the room and Catra supposes that maybe Bow *did* listen to her a bit. She lets out a low whistle as Glimmer and Adora blink at him before looking at each other and then back at him once more.

Graciously, Catra decides to throw him a bone. “Look, I’m not supposed to be here. This is some weird, freak space-time anomaly bullshit.” Bravely, she looks right to Adora and ignores the low swoop of her stomach as she does, “And *you* know Razz is the only person weird enough to cut through space and time. So Bow was helping me find her so I could leave. By helping me, he was helping you guys.”

Adora just blinks and the only response she can muster is, “Razz isn’t weird. She’s uh, kind of strange, I guess--”

Catra just sighs, ignoring the swell of affection that rises in her chest at Adora’s rambling. “Doesn’t matter, point is, no one was even supposed to find out I was here. If you left me go, I’ll be out of your hair.”

“Psh, yeah, *okay* ,” Glimmer snorts, “Like we’re just going to let you *go* .”

“You seriously want *two* of me around? If you don’t believe me, check the Fright Zone. Or Salineas, if you wanna be more exact,” Catra fights back. She isn’t gloating or smug. She’s not proud of the damage she’s done, the kind that cannot be rebuilt in just two years post-war. Helping the water princess with reconstruction is next on her to-do list. Right after saving Angella.

“Salineas,” Bow repeats, “How did you know about Salineas?”

Shit . Her eyes widen at her mistake, and if she were thinking a bit quicker on her feet she would remember to keep her composure. She tries to recover quickly, “Been there, done that, got the fucking regret for it. I told you, some shit happened the same where I’m from-”

“Right,” Bow narrows his eyes, “It’s just that I don’t think you ever mentioned *how* similar things were.”

“Are you seriously mad that *Catra* of all people lied to you?” Glimmer looks at him in exasperation, “After *everything* she’s done, this is what’s the most surprising?”

Catra tries not to full-body wince at that.

“I told you, this Catra is different!” Bow defends, but it doesn’t make Catra feel that much better, “I mean, just--look at her.”

Catra feels herself flush a bit, everyone's eyes on her now. Adora has *been* staring, but now Glimmer’s eyes feel like they are burning against her skin. This is also fucking exhausting, have everyone debating her truth right in front of her.

This isn’t even her normal attire. She picked it out for that stupidly sweet date Adora planned and *shit* , now she’s just thinking of how crestfallen Adora looked when Catra ran away from her at breakneck speed.

“Stop fucking staring at me,” Catra snaps, “Look if you let me go, I promise I’ll just *leave* .”

“Razz helped then?” Bow asks.

“Uh, not really. I just need to go to Mystacor and talk to Casta--” She’s entangling more and more people in this web of people she’ll eventually have to use the seraphinite on, but...

“So you’re not leaving?” Glimmer questions, “You’re just going to *stick* around here? Guys, clearly she’s lying. She can’t even stick to one story.”

“I don’t want to be here!” Catra is yelling now, “You think I want to be stuck reliving all of this *bullshit* ? I can hardly tolerate you guys in the present, never fucking mind now!”

It is a lie. She goes above and beyond merely tolerating them. But it also it unravels all of her other lies; making her want to punch her way out of this stupid magic rune but they’re never going to let her go -

“She’s telling the truth.”

It’s Adora’s voice that cuts through the chaos of the room, Catra’s panic, Glimmer gearing herself up for a scathing retort, and the look of realization on Bow’s face. Catra turns her body to look at Adora, meeting her eye for the briefest of seconds.

Her expression is guarded and largely impossible to decipher but Catra could swear there is something familiar. A fleeting gleam, one that has been exchanged so many times across drill lineups or reconstruction meetings when they had to conspire in secret.

It is there one second and gone the next, but it still makes Catra’s stomach absolutely lurch. It’s too much, Adora can’t possibly look at her like that, not now, not at the height of her cruelty…

“Adora!” Glimmer scolds, “Private meeting! Now!”

She yanks Adora away by the red collar of her jacket. Bow makes a move to follow, but Glimmer turns around and utters, “Don’t even *think* about it.”

The door slams shut behind her. Bow can leave, he is not trapped in a rune like Catra, and perhaps maybe he *should* make a break for it, but he stays.

There is not much moral ground for Catra to fight for, but that doesn't stop her from trying. "So, was it worth it? Selling me out?"

He doesn't fall for it. "You lied to me, didn't you?"

"I…" Catra scrambles for her half-truths, "I'm not this Catra--"

"You *are* though," Bow walks over to her, anger pinched in his brow.

" *No* I'm not!" She disputes, Melog jumping to all-fours beside her. "Didn't you get the reports about Salineas? Clearly I couldn't have been all the way out there if you just saw me a few hours ago!"

It's a flimsy work around and Bow isn't buying it. "You said you could barely tolerate us in the *present.* Does that mean this is the past for you?"

His voice is curt, resolve absolute and gaze hardened as he awaits her response.

"Maybe," She mumbles, glancing to the side before looking back up at him. He still seems wildly displeased with her, so she relents. The truth is unavoidable now anyway. "Fine. I'm from the future. There. Are you happy?"

"No!' his answer is quick, impassioned, "No, I'm not happy. Why did you lie to me? Against my better judgement I actually trusted you, and now my best friends think I betrayed them. Why are you even here? And Razz - you didn't hurt her, did you?"

Catra turns her stare into a thin glare, scoffing as she asks, "Are you serious? Why would I hurt an old woman?"

Razz may have really ticked her off with her nonanswers, but Catra would never hurt her.

“Why should I believe you?” He eyes her skeptically, “I was right about you. All you’ve ever done is hurt my friends, and then you came here and *lied to* me just to get me to help you!”

“Oh please, spare me your little soap box speech,” She crosses her arms, “If I had told you the truth, you never would’ve helped me. And not like it matters much, seeing as you betrayed me *anyway* .”

“I didn’t sell you out! Double Trouble must’ve seen us, then they shape-shifted into you after we caught them *spying* and it was all over from there,” Bow explains.

Fuck. Double Trouble. Ugh. Catra should’ve known -

“And obviously you must’ve known that DT was a spy, seeing as *you* paid them to be so we could be distracted long enough for you to take over Salineas,” He accuses, “So whatever you were telling me about us being friends clearly has to be a lie -”

“I couldn’t tell you and risk messing up the timeline,” Catra interjects.

“Oh, so now you care about messing up space and time?” He remains unswayed by her response.

“Look, I might’ve lied about a few things,” Catra hisses, still incensed by his earlier comment, “But I didn’t lie about us being friends.

“Then what else did you lie about?” He presses his lips into a thin line.

“I wasn’t...going to Razz to figure out how to go home. I know how to get back to my time, I just...I needed to figure out how to go deeper into the past.” She pushes the words out, grumbling at her own failures. “I was never supposed to end up here, alright?”

“Where were you trying to go?” Bow narrows his eyes. After she doesn’t answer, stubbornly avoiding his stare, he prompts again,

“What are you trying to do, Catra?”

Catra . He says her name so roughly now, it’s hard to believe he can ever say it with a silver of affection in the future. How did they ever progress past this? Or is Bow just a really great actor - *or* is she just so dumb that she fell for half hearted declarations of friendship?

Maybe Adora isn’t the one who’s grown soft. Maybe it's her -

“Get Adora to never leave the Horde?” He asks as she continues to spiral down her thoughts, “When are you going to learn that will never happen?”

“That’s not what I was doing,” She bristles at the accusation.

She is well aware that Adora had to leave. She’s accepted that much, accepted that while Adora could’ve gone about it *better* , it was very much inevitable. Moreover, she has accepted that everything that had gone wrong between them did not boil down to that one singular choice; it had been a cascade of decisions made by themselves - and others, both before and after Adora found the sword.

“What’s worse is that you tried to get me to *lie* to her,” He carries on, “Adora is my best friend. And I got lost for a second because everything...has been so hard lately. But I’m not letting you hurt her or anyone else, and no matter what you do, Adora, Glimmer and I are always going to be best friends. You can’t take that away from us. No matter how hard you try to change the past, we’re always going to find each other and look out for each other. Because that’s what friends *do.* ”

She’d have a hard time swallowing these words even if he was correct about her intent. But what’s worse is that he’s got it all wrong.

“I don’t want to *hurt* Adora!” Her voice is loud, snappish. He blinks up at her in surprise. “I don’t want to change the past, I wanted to go back to the portal and undo my biggest *fucking* mistake and

get Angella out of there because if you think it's hard to believe that we're friends in the future, imagine how *I* feel! You guys act like what happened with Angella isn't my fault but I know that's not true. There's no way you don't *hate* me for it. Not you. Not Glimmer and definitely not Adora. Even I hate myself for it."

Melog makes a distressed noise at her feet, but whatever. It's not like that's *news* .

"Catra…" Bow is looking at her, eyes wide but not disbelieving.

"So if you can't admit it, fine. Whatever, I don't care. Point is, I just want to bring Angella back because…" Her shoulders deflate, unsure if she can admit the words on the tip of her tongue. "Maybe one day you'll stop hating me if I do."

He is looking at her sadly now, way too close to pity. So she brings a rough edge back to her voice, "And spare me the bullshit about friendship, alright? I don't care whether or not you believe *us* being friends, but I've been friends with Adora way before you came into the picture, and maybe it took us sometime to work our shit out, but we're friends now, too. That's why I'm doing this-"

"You're doing this for us," He repeats, "But Adora, too."

"That's what I just said, isn't it?" She narrows her eyes into slits.

"You care about her. A lot." It's a simple observation. "That doesn't just happen over night."

Catra ignores him, "Look, you told me earlier you *wished* it was me in this universe. So congrats! Your wish came true. But if you want me to...become *this* person and not the horrible monster who set you up with a spy and took down Salineas in a day then you have to let me go. You need to get Glimmer to let me *go* ."

"It's not that simple," Bow frowns, "There's a lot going on right now-"

“I know!” Catra interjects, “Trust me, *I know.* I lived it through once and I don’t have any interest in living through it again. You don’t understand, I have to get back--”

Every second she’s here grates on her more and more, it’s just another second she’s left Adora waiting. Crushed. Confused-

“If we let you go, are you going to your present or are you still going to try to go into the past?” Bow fixes her with a flat look.

She decides to be honest this time. “I can’t go back to my time until I finish this.”

“Why?” He assesses her, looking down at Melog who sends him back an affronted look as if to tell him that there is no *real* reason why.

“Because I just *can’t* .” She feels her hands ball into fists at her side.

“How am I supposed to help you if you still won’t tell me the truth?” He asks.

“I love her, okay?” Catra says before she can really think better of it, before she can really pay attention to the volume of her voice or the emotion behind it. Her words don’t really register with Bow, not for a moment or so when she continues, “I love her. And she--she says she loves me too. She wants us to have a future. But I can’t...and I know I don’t *deserve* one with her until I fix this.”

Bow’s brain looks just about broken, Melog makes some weak protests that Catra pushes out of her mind.

“Adora?” He asks, but he doesn’t need to. His face softens just a moment later as the realization dawns on him. “That... *wow* . That actually-uh... *huh* - kind of makes things make sense.”

“What does that mean?” She asks, wrinkling her nose.

But then, suddenly, the door bursts open. Adora stands behind it, looking a little on edge, a little flustered, a little *guilty.* She sees Bow and Catra staring at her and coughs awkwardly. She tries to harden her expression, but Catra can easily discern the swirl of emotions inside.

"Bow. Glimmer wants to talk to you." She says, using her thumb to point to the hallway.

Catra looks to him, eyes pleading. Her hand, instinctively reaches out to him, to grab his wrist-to get him to stay, *anything* , but the rune blocks her. She winces as the magic lights up, unable to contain her full body flinch.

He looks remiss, dropping his voice to a whisper, "Look. About what you said earlier, about being a monster? I don't know if that's true. Good people can make...bad choices. Sometimes-I've learned. And to be clear, I could've done without the biting or the throwing me off a cliff, but...you defended me to Glimmer. You gave me advice when you didn't have to. And you're trying to save Angella…"

"What are you saying?" She asks.

Bow takes a deep breath, "I don't think you're a horrible person. Maybe you never were."

She flinches again - even if his words are not hurtful, they're still *shocking* .

"I don't know what I would've done if you told me the truth but...that was my choice to make, and it was wrong for you to lie about it." He remarks pointedly. Her ears turn downwards, conveying her guilt.

"I know. I messed up," She admits, biting her cheek, "I just... *thought* I was protecting the timeline by not telling you. But I guess that doesn't matter now."

He nods in understanding. “I know. I’ll...try to argue your case. I can’t make any promises but...I’ll try.”

Catra mumbles her thanks. It’s half hearted, but she’s sort of *panicking* right now and her options feel so limited and she doesn’t like her escape plan riding on the ally she has effectively screwed over about three times now.

But it’s enough for him. He gives her a tight-lipped smile and says, “I take back what I said before. I get why we’re friends.”

And then he just *walks away.* The words rattle her, meant to be a balm, they only burn and leave a trail of embers in their wake. Surely he can’t mean them but -

He leaves, Adora’s eyes flicker to him and back to Catra - the latter pointedly looking away. When the door clicks with a soft close, Catra exhales and looks up. Grateful for a moment alone with Melog to gather her thoughts and sort through her feelings but -

Uh . What the hell, she’s very much not alone because Adora hasn’t left for some reason. Quite the opposite actually, Adora is walking towards her with a schooled look of determination on her face.

“Catra,” Adora’s voice is not full of contempt, not like it was the last time Catra had seen her at this point in their lives.

“Well,” Catra aims for casual, tries to keep her cool, as if this isn’t totally freaking her out right now, “What’s the verdict?”

Adora looks up at her, her face wavering for just a second, “Glimmer isn’t happy.”

“You don’t say?” Catra drawls. “The world suddenly has two of me, and the Queen isn’t cartwheeling with utter joy and exuberation?”

To her complete surprise, Adora laughs. She startles at the way the noise abruptly comes out of her, almost forgetting she is meant to be the bearer of some important news. "I...yeah. Not exactly."

Something is off with her. Catra narrows her eyes, "I don't suppose you heard any of my conversation with Bow, did you?"

Adora's face flashes red with guilt at being caught, even if it isn't entirely her fault. Catra had been loud, after all. She coughs awkwardly into her hand and Catra can't help but smirk, "...Part of it. I believe you, okay? I mean, obviously you...you're not Catra."

She sounds so sad that Catra's heart swoops lowly in her chest.

"Not this Catra, I guess. She made it pretty clear that she - she'll never...yeah."

Don't you get it? I am never *going to go with you!*

Oh. Adora believes the lie for all the wrong reasons.

Adora removes the sword from the wristlet, a slight glow emanating at the very center of the runestone, and holds it up to the entrapment rune.

"What are you doing?" Catra asks, a bit bewildered as She-Ra's magic is channeled through the sword.

She worries, briefly, if she should be preparing herself for some sort of altercation. Her body groans in protest at the mere thought of fighting Adora again. She hasn't been keeping up with her training as much now that the war has long since ended, but she can still hold her own if necessary.

Although it looks like she won't have to. Adora isn't transforming, she's bringing the charged sword into the ground near the rune. The stone cracks a little underneath the current of magic, but Catra could give a shit less about flooring right now.

Because Adora is *breaking* the rune -

“You’re letting me go?” She asks, tone aghast and steeped in disbelief. “Why?”

“Because...you don’t belong here,” Adora shrugs, but her eyes are cold and guarded. “You should be able to go home.”

“But…” Catra trails off, Melog chiding her with a soft rowl. She doesn’t want to convince Adora *not* to help her, but she doesn’t quite understand. “Why? After everything that’s happened here?”

“You said we’re friends where you’re from?” Adora asks, clearly not having heard *all* of Catra’s conversation with Bow. When Catra nods, Adora continues. “Well...we used to be here, but we’re not anymore. And I just know that…if I were the Adora from wherever you came from, I would want you to come back.”

“You want me to come back?” Catra asks, confused before clarifying. “I mean—me, here. Now.”

Adora looks at her with mirrored confusion. Not because she doesn’t understand Catra’s question, but moreso doesn’t understand how it is even a question in the first place.

“If we’re not friends here—if you *lost* Salineas and Queen Angella because of her, and she opened the portal and tried to destroy the entire world,” Catra stammers out, voice a bit shaky, “ *why* would you want to still be friends with her? I mean, how could you even have any hope?”

Adora should’ve given up on her at this point. She had, to Catra’s knowledge.

But she just looks at Catra with wistful resignation, “She made her choice. And I...I wish it wasn’t like this. I tried but she doesn’t… doesn’t want us to be friends or even stop fighting. So no, I don’t have any hope that will change but... just because she won’t change her mind doesn’t mean *you* or the people from your universe should pay for it.”

It’s so on the nose, Adora isn’t even *trying* for it to be, but it leaves Catra stupefied regardless.

“Don’t you hate her?” Is all Catra can think to ask. She doesn’t really want the answer, but she has to know. “I mean, I wouldn’t blame you. After everything-”

“No,” Adora’s voice is firm, if a bit tired. It isn’t the impassioned response she had given Catra on Darla after saving her from Prime. It lacks any emotionality. It is a statement of fact. “I don’t think I could ever hate her. Maybe I’m just being stupid and should hate her because obviously she hates me but - but I can’t. ”

She rubs her arm awkwardly, still avoiding Catra’s gaze. “Anyway, you should probably get out of here before - “

“I’m sorry,” Catra interrupts her. Adora’s eyes go wide as she looks up to the foreign version of her enemy. “I’m sorry I… I came here, and I brought all of this up for you. You’re doing the right thing, now. Finally seeing her as the enemy.”

Adora looks surprised and a little hurt by the confirmation.

“I know it isn’t easy. But you’re doing a great job. Regardless of what Glimmer or anyone else says.”

She can’t stop herself, but it’s not like it matters because she’s already dug herself this hole. Adora should know. Even if it’s just for a few seconds before her memory is erased, she should at least *know* . Someone should tell her how strong, how brave she is. How good she is doing for someone who carries the weight of the world on her back.

It’s not surprising when Adora tears up a bit at Catras words. “No matter the time. No matter the universe, you’re the strongest person I know. And you’ve always been more than enough .”

Catra grabs her and pulls her in for a hug. Maybe it’s easier to say these words than to focus on what Adora and Bow have said,

maybe it's therapeutic to be there for Adora in a way her past self never could've been.

"You've always been more than enough." She repeats for additional emphasis.

She is tense, rightfully a bit untrusting. Catra is about to pull away but then Adora melts into the hug, locking her arms around Catra so tightly it nearly squeezes the doubt out of her. Catra wonders when the last time Adora had been hugged at this point. She knows stupid displays of affection are a staple of the Best Friend Squad, but Adora clings to her like a lifeline.

Adora doesn't hate her now. And if she didn't hate her *now* , then she certainly never did. Catra can't understand why - or *what* Adora sees in her but-

The door flies open again, Glimmer appearing in a rage with Bow and Double Trouble dragged behind her. Catra takes the opportunity to fix them with a *glare* but they merely throw her a wink in response

"The *future?* " Glimmer accuses, very clearly seething.

Catra pulls away from Adora, the latter looking rather confused. "Glimmer - what?"

"And what are *you* doing, helping her?" Glimmer demands, "Why is the only person being honest with me the shapeshifting *spy* ?"

"I was being honest!" Bow argues from her grasp, before sending Catra a pleading look, "I thought the truth would help!"

"The truth?" Adora looks back to Catra, but doesn't entirely let her go.

"She's not from a different universe Adora," Glimmer huffs, "Just a different *time* ."

Adora looks to Catra in surprise - recognition slowly dawning across her features as the implications of their conversation sink it. “Wait. What. We-you?”

She doesn’t look upset - just so stupidly hopeful. It’s the same look she had on her face last night.

And unlike last night, Catra gives a response. A *yes* .

But there is no time to revel in the marvel on Adora’s face.

Now is our chance , Melog tells her. Catra had gotten so caught up in everything that’s just happened that she nearly forgot -

But they’re right. She’s free now. Everyone who she’s dragged into this is *here* , and she has to act quickly before the bullshit can ripple outwards and ruin any chance she has of correcting the timeline. She rummages through the bag, grabs the seraphinite while Glimmer attempts to clamour towards her.

“In what future are we *friends* ?” Glimmer demands, teleporting herself on top of Catra and wrestling her to the ground.

As she does, the gem hits the ground and shatters. Catra makes an indignant noise and struggles to get out of Glimmer’s hold.

“Do you honestly expect me to just let you go, after everything?” Glimmer tightens her grasp, seemingly surprised by Catra’s divided attention. “You can’t *honestly* expect me to believe you’re here to save my mother!”

“Glimmer, let her go!” Bow calls out.

“You only ever cared about yourself!” Glimmer ignores him, pressing firmly on Catra’s wrists. “You don’t care that you hurt people, and people like you *never* change!”

“That’s enough Glimmer,” Adora tries to intervene, but Glimmer snaps her eyes towards her.

“Stay back,” Glimmer says to Adora, eyes fierce and fiery, “You-”

Whatever words are about to pour out of her mouth are likely set to scar, so Catra intervenes.

“You’re right,” Catra says, and Glimmer looks down at her with surprise. Out of the corner of her eye, she can see Melog make themselves invisible. “I hurt a lot of people. And I can’t expect you to believe me. Or even forgive me.”

Glimmer looks at her in surprise, her grasp loosening just slightly *enough* .

“But I’m not going to let you stop me,” Catra uses the moment to kick her legs up and push Glimmer off of her just enough to give Melog room to pounce.

She rolls onto her side and grabs a shard of the gem.

“Catra, don’t-” Adora’s voice cuts through the commotion of Glimmer trying to push Melog off of her, Bow’s scramble as he figures out *what* to do and DT’s cackle at the chaos they helped create.

Catra. Please. Don’t.

It’s different this time. Before, it was to hurt Adora and all of her friends.

But now, Catra is turning her back to protect them. The future that’s worth fighting for; worth a drop of blood as she pricks her finger on the sharpened gem.

Emulating the color of the seraphinite, a green smoke clouds the room. Melog grabs Catra, dragging them out into the hallway before they can feel the effects. The door is slammed behind them and the room falls silent for a moment. They are cloaked under Melogs invisibility anxiously waiting for a sign that the gem has worked when -

“Wh-what? What happened?” Adora is the first to speak.

“What did you do?” Glimmer’s voice, accusatory, comes next.

“Me? I didn’t do anything, darling-”

“I find that hard to believe coming from the *spy* !”

Arguing ensues, but there is no mention of Catra outside of the context of the Horde commander who set up the elaborate scheme.

With a heavy sigh, Catra rummages through her bag and pulls out the sapphire. She failed. The whole thing spun wildly out of control. With no Razz, no idea how to move *backwards* and no failsafe, she would be a fool to stay here for even a second longer.

“Guess this is it,” She mutters to herself, heart heavy. No closer to figuring out how she can face anyone back home, but knowing it is the only option left.

Melog snatches the sapphire from her hand with their mouth, looking at her in challenge before running a few feet ahead of her.

“Hey!” she whispers yells, “What do you think you're doing? That’s our ticket home!”

There is one last place we need to go , they tell her.

Chapter End Notes

> i am sooo sorry for the delay, the chapter wound up getting too long (surprise surprise) so I'm splitting it up. the final chapter should be posted next week!

hold your hand

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

You were so certain Adora hated you for the person you used to be, Melog tells her as she follows them through familiar, maze-like tunnels. Her skin crawls just with the mere thought of being here again. *Glimmer and Bow, too.*

"Well it's not like I would blame them if they did," Catra scoffs, keeping her voice just above a whisper even though Melog has cloaked them.

The Fright Zone isn't overly crowded right now. There are still some troops that are rolling back from Salineas, others that have been stationed in recently-acquired villages. But without any seraphinite left, Catra is not interested in taking any risks.

And that is the problem , they respond. *There is only one person who hates the past you.*

"I wouldn't be too sure of that," Catra rolls her eyes, "I've made quite a bit of enemies, if you couldn't tell that from the - oh, I don't know, *everything* about me?"

I am sure. *I know your heart, Catra.* Melog rebuffs and she stiffens upon realizing where exactly Melog has decided to take her.

That's the problem. Melog doesn't know her, not like they think they do. They know her *after* saving Glimmer; after Adora saved her from Prime and she had already joined the Rebellions side.

Your heart didn't change , Melog tells her, *it only grew.*

"Okay, we can't be here," she ignores them. "Are you forgetting that we don't have any seraphinite left? We can't go strolling

around here - we have to get back home before someone sees us and everything gets fucked up!”

It will only take a moment, they respond, pushing past the slightly open door. The one that leads to a place that Catra knows all too well.

Her Force Captain chambers.

And - yeah. There she is. Hair long, eyes tired and tone as cutting and harsh as a shard of glass as she barks orders out at some cadets. Once she’s done, they scramble out of the room, anxious to get away before falling victim to any further verbal reprimands.

Catra feels a wave of disgust just looking at her younger self, making a move to step away but Melog curls around her feet.

Visiting the Fright Zone in the present is hard enough. Only made bearable by the knowledge that she is purging it of all that it used to be, preparing the land for a rule under Scorpia and Perfuma’s unity. But now-

Now flashbacks come in a steady assault. From Hordak, to Shadow Weaver, to sad, fleeting memories of her childhood, she sees it all. *Feels* it all. Feels everything she’s tried to parse from herself, the defensive anger, the paranoia. The pain and *loneliness.* The push and pull of wanting to construct walls around her heart so no one could hurt her again but then finding herself feeling incredibly alone.

In front of Catra now is someone who was never good enough. Never worth a kind word from her superiors or a shred of mercy. Never a good enough Force Captain either. Not a good enough friend - scratch that, she was fucking *terrible.*

Always so angry. Defensive. Rude. Paranoid. *Loud*. Insecure. Too stupid, too blind to see how she was destroying herself from the inside out. Bad. Wrong. Disgusting. Worthless.

And - *crying.* Catra blinks slowly as she watches younger-Catra brace one hand against the far door, barring anyone else from entering, while the other catches tears and wipes them from her face.

If you truly believe that everyone hated her at this time, why would you do the same? Surely, she must deserve compassion from someone, Melog questions.

"No," Catra's response is a low, quiet snarl. She remembers this vaguely, remembers getting upset and crying over whatever stupid thing she had done to herself more than once. "She doesn't."

She ignores the pang in her heart - an echo of sympathy, as she watches her younger self turn so that her back is up against the wall, sinking to the ground and tucking her knees to her chest as she continues to cry.

Anger flares within her. *Good*. She should cry - shouldn't she? After all she's done to hurt everyone else, *crying* is the least she can do. Actually, she shouldn't even be doing that much. What right does she have to throw a god damn pity party for herself?

Melog tries a different approach. *What would you say if you saw Adora like this?*

Catra feels - feels... *torn*. "I'm not Adora. Doesn't matter."

You love her, don't you?

"Would you stop?" She whisper-hisses, glaring down at them. "Obviously I do."

And she loves you. Catra looks away, the evidence for that is now harder to refute than ever before. *As do your friends. As do I.*

"You all love who I am now," She corrects.

Who you were is part of who you are , is the rebuff.

Sadly, she glances back at herself. Melog's voice comes back to her head, *And if we can love every part of you, perhaps you can too.*

"No." Catra's staunch refusal leads to her balling her hands into fists at her side. "I don't--I don't *deserve* that."

And why not?

"Because - I was a monster," she scowls. "I hurt a lot of people."

But you don't anymore. You learned. You didn't want to hurt people anymore, so you stopped. Is that not enough?

"It doesn't *undo* all of the shit I did! I-"

You have spent much time trying to undo the damage you've caused. A lot of time spent forgiving others for how they've hurt you.

She doesn't have a response for that.

All you knew was how to hurt and be hurt , Melog reminds her her. *Once you realized it didn't have to be that way, you stopped.*

"So what?" Her argument is as weak as her voice.

If you were truly a monster - why would you stop hurting people?

"I don't know!" Catra is exasperated and anxious and doesn't really care what Melog has to say right now. "All I know is that *she* isn't-she can't..."

I'll prove it to you.

Catra's eyes widen and she makes a move to stop Melog before they can do anything ridiculous that will get them both caught, but they easily evade her grasp. She flails a bit, trying not to make much noise, as Melog transforms into something she has not seen before. They are larger than their usual cat form, but not *too* big,

looking closer to the size and shape of a...wolf maybe? She isn't quite sure, looking on curiously as Melog changes their coat to a lighter grey color.

She's genuinely stumped at what they're trying to do - she's only seen a creature like the form Melog has taken maybe once before but that was -

Oh. Wait -

They are changing themselves so that Catra won't recognize them when they meet on Krytis. Which means they plan on actually interacting with her past self - oh *no*. Catra makes another move towards them but they silently bound away.

"What do you think you're doing?" She demands, knowing fully well that she's going to be ignored.

They give a small shake to their larger coat, shaking off their invisibility cloak while Catra herself remains covered. Her ears twitch as she thinks *stop stop stop* on a loop and hopes Melog picks up on the feeling.

Her younger self, so caught up in her dismayed state, doesn't even see Melog coming. They walk over to her, sniffing at the air around her curiously when she detects them. She snaps her head up with a vague noise of confusion before they bound over to her and lick the side of her face.

The reaction is immediate.

"Ew! What the hell are you doing?" She pushes Melog away, "Who are you - how the hell did you even get in here?"

Catra winces at the sound of that voice, high pitched and demanding. Melog isn't deterred though, they simply raise a paw and place it on her shoulder.

"Get off of me," She snarls before pushing them away again, "Seriously? Who let you in here? Was it Kyle?"

Angrily she wipes the tear tracks from her face as they tilt her head and look at her curiously. She points at the door and commands, "Leave - get out of here."

Instead of following orders, Melog drops to all fours, with their back hunched upwards as they give a playful wag of their tail.

"What are you doing?" Her younger self asks, but there is slightly less anger in her voice. Looking at her, Cata could swear there might even be the slightest twitch of a smile tugging at her lips. Cautiously, past-Catra lifts a hand out to pet them and it's all the invitation they need to dart off to the side, grabbing a file full of papers in their mouth and running.

"Hey!" She gasps, affronted - but it's a little breathless. A little amused. Catra smiles too, she might not know what Melog is playing at here but it is *funny* to watch them give her younger self the chase. "Get back here!"

She jumps to her feet to follow them. Melog pauses every few seconds to let her catch up before leaping to their feet again and bolting. Catra finds herself stifling her own laughter before realizing with shock that her *younger* self is laughing too.

Giggling, she might even dare to think.

Her heart feels funny, lodged in her throat as she watches the scene unfold. Melog eventually relents by dropping the file onto the floor and rolling onto their back on top of it, giving her younger self an imploring look. She takes the bait, kneeling down beside them to pet them, and Melog takes the opportunity to jump on her and lick her face.

Younger-Catra makes a disgusted noise, but it is laced with affection. She's laughing as they continue to wrestle a bit. And that noise - the sound of her laugh, takes Catra back. Suddenly, she doesn't see a monster; a selfish, embittered horde commander. Instead she sees a *child*. Her youngest, purest self, laughing and lighthearted - even in the lowest point of her life.

The pang in her heart turns into a *crack.* And through that crack slips away the feelings of anger and disgust, suddenly flooded out by an influx of sadness.

And *oh* , is this what Razz was talking about? Is this why Adora never hated her? Why Glimmer and Bow were able to look past her wrongdoings and see someone worth befriending?

She looks at herself and sees someone who is lost. Mislead, hurt, angry - but still…at her core, good. *Good*.

It is hard, it is a flagrant battle against every part of her brain that tells her this version of herself should be cut out and rejected. But Catra sees this part of herself and suddenly doesn't *want* to do those things. She wants to accept her, doesn't want to hurt her or look down on her like so many have. Wants to understand her. Love her, maybe. One day.

Melog peers up over at her, *See? Same heart. Not such a monster, after all.*

And sure it is easy to see that, with her younger self allowing in a rare moment of vulnerability. But - maybe she has to *start* here. She knows, somewhere, that the anger was adaptive at one point. A way of protecting herself, but it is still not easy to accept.

Cautiously and still cloaked, Catra walks over to them. She takes a deep breath and crouches down next to them.

She can't speak, can't give notice to her presence. But she knows what she would say if she could.

I'm sorry.

You're going to be okay.

I'm building a better life for us.

And, perhaps the hardest - the words she would choke on if she could speak them:

Thank you.

There are tears streaming down her face as she reaches forward and places a gentle hand on her younger self's shoulder. It is only a second of contact, trying to push some level of comfort into her younger self- before younger Catra jumps and turns around. Her eyes scan the room, looking for the source and coming up empty.

A moment later, the door opens and cadets come forth. It is a moment of distraction, enough for Melog to slip away, cloaking themselves before transforming into their usual form.

Younger Catra blinks in confusion at the sudden loss, mumbles something about needing more sleep. There is something sad, remorseful in her stare.

Catra smiles sadly at her, watching as she tries to recover and put on a brave face for the cadets.

You're doing the best you can.

Still unsure if she believes that much, but she has to start somewhere. Best doesn't have to mean *right* , after all.

Melog leads Catra to the side and they retreat through an open door.

They drop the sapphire into her hand and say, *It's time to go.*

When Catra opens her eyes, she finds herself back in Micah's study. Feeling a little nauseous, she clutches onto Melog for a moment longer, closing her eyes and breathing in deeply.

Seeing Micah here is all the confirmation she needs to know that she's back home at least. She lets gratitude wash over her, counting her blessings to be back in her present- where she belongs.

“Welcome back,” Micah says, turning away from a bookshelf to face her.

She expected him to look disappointed-more disappointed than anyone else, really. But he’s got a soft, almost relieved, smile on his face. He extends a hand to her and helps her off of the floor.

Cautiously she accepts it, eyeing him wearily. His first words were one of welcome, not even a question of where his *wife* is or what had happened.

Which can only mean one thing.

“You knew, didn’t you?” She doesn’t bother keeping the accusation out of her voice. “You knew it wouldn’t work.”

“I’ve found that looking backwards isn’t a feasible way to build a future,” Micah replies diplomatically, “Perhaps the only way to change course is to start right where you are.”

“Why? Why did you just *let* me do that, knowing it wouldn’t work?” She asks, awestruck. She’s not used to being outsmarted. “I mean--what if it did? What if the crystal took me exactly where I needed to go, how did you know it would *fail* ?”

“I don’t recall you giving me much of a choice,” He corrects, gently, “Besides, it didn’t fail. How could it? The purpose of the quartz was to take you where you needed to be.”

“Don’t you care about your wife?” Catra is still scrambling for words, grappling with the conclusion she’s landed on, “I mean, why even waste time with this stupid time travel bullshit?”

“Do you think it was a waste of time?” He counters, looking at her thoughtfully.

Catra pauses for a moment. Remembers her conversations with Bow, Razz’s cryptic advice - her discovery that Adora never truly hated her.

She remembers looking at herself - her reigning second-in command-self with something akin to kindness for the first time ever.

“No. I don’t.”

“Well, there you have it,” Micah seems pleased with her answer.

“What about Angella?” She asks because she can’t *help it*. Maybe she has realized that there’s no reason to punish herself over and over again, but that doesn’t magically wash away her guilt or hurt.

“Angella was never stuck in the past,” Micah says pointedly, “From my understanding, the Portal does not adhere to the standard laws of space and time. Hypothetically, if I were to figure out a way to open the Portal right this very second, I’d be able to find her. I’ve been thinking of a way to do so without endangering the fabric of our reality.”

“I...that makes sense, I guess,” she mutters.

“Catra. I hope you’ve learned by now that you can’t change the past. The only way to change your future is to start with yourself, here, in the present,” He tells her, “ *All* of yourself.”

“Couldn't you have just told me that in the beginning and spared me the trip?” She hisses, crossing her arms. He tried to, she knows he did but - still.

Instead, Micah carries on with his point, “We’re all flawed.”

“I know, I know. Trust me, I *learned* ,” She glances at Melog, “If I’m going to forgive others...I should *try* , I guess, to forgive myself.”

He nods approvingly, “Good. Because I was thinking my plan could use some assistance. Perhaps from someone with a bit of experience with the intricacies of time travel, Portals and the like.”

“Oh,” She blinks at him, ear twitching with interest. She’s surprised at the offer, but he seems genuine about it.

“Only if you’re willing to share some of the responsibility of attempting to fix everything,” Micah offers a small joke.

“Yeah. I guess that sounds like a fair deal,” She agrees.

“Well, we can start tomorrow,” He sighs, clapping some of the dust from the bookshelf off of his hands. “As for right now...I understand you have a few people you might want to catch up with.”

Catra winces, “How long was I gone for, exactly?”

“Just over a day.”

“Right,” A grimace falls over her face as she steps to the doorway. Before she looks over her shoulder, “Look I...don’t know if I’m in the place to say *thank you* yet, because that whole thing fucking sucked, but--maybe one day.”

“Maybe one day,” He echoes with a small smile.

With that, Catra takes off down the hallway as Melog tries to keep pace.

Bow finds her first. Or rather, she finds *Bow* first.

“Catra!” He exclaims with relief lighting his features as he sees her, “We’ve been looking everywhere for you-- *oof*.”

He’s cut off by Catra crushing their bodies together in a tight, gripping hug.

“Uh-are you okay?” He asks, concern tainted in his voice. But it isn’t forced or awkward - it’s her Bow. Her best friend; who saw the good in her before she really saw it in herself. She wraps her arms tighter around his neck at the realization. “Catra?”

“Shut up,” She mutters. “Just-shut up.”

“Got it. Shutting up now,” He relents easily enough, returning her hug in kind, “Don’t think I’ve ever had a Catra-hug before.”

She pulls back then and he’s surprised to see her eyes gleaming with emotion.

“I didn’t do it. I couldn’t.” She offers a choppy explanation, “I tried but--I couldn’t.”

“Catra, It’s okay,” Bow comforts, placing a warm hand on her shoulder. He nods, a knowing look on his face, “Micah filled us in. Everyone is just going to be happy you’re back.”

She breathes deeply, “You think so?”

“As long as you *never* run off like that again,” A stern, almost scolding, look falls over Bow’s features, “Yes.”

“But I-Angella...I wasn’t able to-” Catra frowns, biting back the words *I fucked it up again.*

There have always been major consequences to failure for Catra. And while she doesn’t think anyone will physically hurt her for something they hadn’t even asked her to do, she is still fearful of emotional retribution. Of disappointing everyone by not being able to clean up her own mess.

“I know. It’s okay,” His voice is soft and earnest. “Going back in time to a Portal that’s somehow void of space and time to find someone who’s been stuck there for three years seems...kinda like a tall order.”

Catra looks down. It’s *true* but she’s still not happy with it. She was expecting more of herself.

“No one expected you to do it-especially on our own,” Bow speaks again. “It doesn’t matter whether or not you were able to bring Angella back. What matters is that you’re here now.”

Catra breathes out slowly, “I am. Here, now. And I’m still...someone who tried to destroy the world.”

It’s a heavy burden to admit outloud. She knows now she has to accept this part of herself. It can’t be cut out of her, she understands that now. Saying it is freeing in its own right.

“You are. But you’re someone who helped save it too,” Bow reminds her.

She’d been caught up in her fears that her wrongs outweigh her rights in the end but - perhaps that isn’t necessarily the case. Perhaps one never outweighs the other in the end. Maybe a middle ground - with room to grow is all there truly is.

Catra half-expects Adora to be right where she left her waiting on the balcony. But that’s ridiculous, it’s been over a day after all, and she knows that Adora has been looking for her.

Still, she’s a bit breathless when she reaches the terrace. The air around her is cool, but the sun beats warmly on her face.

The table and the chairs and the lights have all been cleared away. Her shoulders droop, fearful of just how much damage she’s done when -

“Catra?” Adora’s voice causes her to whip around - finding her standing just in the doorway.

There is Adora, just a few feet away. Not the Adora of the past, but *her* Adora. The one who sees her for all of her flaws and never truly gave up on her; the one who knows her, could recount the scars littered across her body even with her eyes closed; the one who she has grown *with* and wants to continue for.

Adora looks fucking exhausted, but her face lights up with sheer relief at seeing Catra. She is tentative, holding herself back right now. Ordinarily, Adora would’ve swooped her up into a hug by this point - but, well…

Catra has some explaining to do.

“Adora,” she breathes out.. Adora’s face softens a bit at the outpouring of reverence in Catra’s voice. But Catra can tell there is a storm of emotions across her face. Hurt, relief, confusion.

She can’t take it a second longer. She closes the space between them by throwing herself into Adora, the latter catching her and wrapping her arms tightly - but Catra is holding her even tighter. Maybe too tight as Adora exhales a small *oof* at the force. But Catra doesn’t care right now, just buries herself into the crook of Adora’s neck and squeezes as if the force of the hug can convey everything she feels.

“Adora, I am so sorry.” Apologies still are not easy for Catra. There is a part of her that fears others will think it is all lip service, not something she truly means but rather a way of getting herself out of trouble. But that’s not true, especially not right *now* - when she is beyond remorseful for not believing in Adora, for hating herself, for being so blinded by her own self hatred that she *ran* without a word. “I mean it.”

Adora is rubbing her hands up and down Catra’s back to comfort her, but Catra pulls back to look at her face. Her face is not stone-set, not fully, but her gaze is still guarded. She keeps her hands on Catra’s arms for a minute before dropping them to her side. “I - what happened, Catra?”

“I got stuck in the past,” Catra explains rubbing her hand over where Adora’s touch used to be on her arm, “I mean, I asked Micah for help but it didn’t work - and then I found out the bastard never *intended* it to work and was just trying to teach me a lesson or, whatever. And there were these gems, but I could only use them once - so once I traveled back in the past, I couldn’t go any further and I had to find Razz, but I didn’t know where she was! And I couldn’t--I didn’t think I could ask you, so I got Bow to help me, but that all blew up because of Double Trouble and Razz-and…”

She isn’t sure if any of what she’s just shared carries even an ounce of cohesion, but her brain and her body still feel scrambled.

“I, wow. That’s confusing,” Adora credits her before redirecting the conversation, “But that’s not what I meant.”

Adora’s gaze feels like it is *burning* her now. Catra dares to look up at her and feels her stomach swoop lowly.

“And I think you know that's not what I meant, too.” Adora accuses, but her tone is far from angry. She just seems sad, but intent on pushing through her emotions for this conversation.

And right, of course. Catra knows what she meant. Knows that she has plenty of time to catch Adora up on all that’s transpired on her journey. It’s not the pressing issue here.

Anticipatory silence falls between them as Catra swallows thickly. Trying to figure out the best way to phrase this, but all she can come up with is -

“I panicked.”

She half expects Adora to do what she does whenever Catra says something obvious - a slight snort accompanied by a ‘no kidding’. But this is serious, and Adora just looks at her with patience.

“I panicked a *lot* , okay?” Catra elaborates. “I...I’ve been kind of panicking. For a while, whenever I think about the future.”

Adora’s mouth is in a thin line. After a few more moments of silence where it becomes clear that Catra isn’t going to say anything else, Adora speaks, “I’m sorry, Catra.” She turns her gaze down to the floor. “I just - still do that thing sometimes where I get so caught up in an idea, and I was just - so sure we were on the same page. But we weren’t, obviously. And I should’ve - *we* should’ve talked about it first.”

“No, no - don’t be sorry,” Catra is hasty to correct, “I-it was sweet. Kinda perfect, actually.” There is a dry, bitter laugh that comes out of her, “ I just…”

Just had to self sabotage. Just had to fuck it up - she kills those thoughts, squeezing her eyes shut for a moment.

“You just... didn’t want this,” Adora finishes for her. Catra opens her eyes and looks at Adora in shock, her girlfriend smiling sadly as she continues to say, “And that’s okay. That’s why we should’ve talked about it before. I just - wish you didn’t run. We could’ve talked about it then, or if you needed space I would’ve given it to you.”

“Adora - ”

She shakes her head looking down at the floor, “But you were just *gone*. And I was worried - I was afraid you wouldn’t come back. All because I got too caught up - I just *stupidly* thought -”

“No, Adora, no. That’s not true,” Catra interrupts her, placing her hands on Adora’s arms and giving her a slight shake, imploring Adora to look up at her. There are tears in both of their eyes, “I - you’re right, I shouldn’t have run like that. But I didn’t run because I didn’t want to marry you.”

Adora blinks in confusion, face flushing at the word *marry*.

“I wanted it. A lot. That’s all I ever wanted - you know? You and I taking on the world together?” Catra ventures because maybe taking *over* the world had always been a misguided attempt at the true sentiment of the words. “But the problem is I - didn’t think I deserved it.”

Adora’s face drops immediately, “Deserve it? What do you mean?”

“After everything that I’ve done,” Catra explains, crossing her arm over the other. Sharpened nails threaten to pierce her skin, but

she releases her grip before they do. "I hurt a lot of people. *You*. Glimmer. Bow. I tried to destroy the world."

"But Catra, I forgave you a long time ago. I know it's still hard and we both struggle sometimes but...I know why you did what you did. And look at everything you've done since then," Adora argues.

"I know. I *know* I've...changed a lot since then. But I had...have a hard time accepting the fact that's who I was, at some point. I wished I could...get rid of that part of myself," Catra confesses. Adora takes a sharp inhale. "And I know thats not possible but...I guess the hardest thing to live with has been *Angella*. I took her away from her family, whether or not I wanted to, that's ultimately what wound up happening. And I just...couldn't see myself deserving a future after I took hers away."

"Catra," Adora is frowning now. "I don't - I wouldn't *want* you to get rid of that part of yourself. I love you. Not just for who you are now, but for who you've been."

Adora's hands frame her face now, gentle and warm. Catra gasps at the tenderness of both the words *and* the contact.

"I don't want a future with only the Catra who saved Glimmer from Prime. I want a future with the Catra I've known since we were kids, the one who bit my arm and *latched on* when we first met," Adora says teasingly.

"You pulled my tail first," She mutters with a small smile.

"I want you for who you were when we were little and every version since then," Adora promises her. "I love you."

Catra believes her, now. After seeing her past self again, the wonder in younger-Adora's eyes at the prospect of them just being friends. She can't doubt it.

Catra is tearing up maybe just a little but - who can *blame* her. "I--I feel the same." She wants to say more, but there is so much emotion lodged in her throat.

Don't you get it? I love you, I always have! - perhaps the statement is reciprocal.

Adora knows well enough. Of course she does. She brushes her thumb across Catra's cheek before leaning their foreheads together until they're touching.

"I just kind of...hate myself sometimes," Catra winces at the confession, feeling slightly ashamed. "But I don't want to - anymore. I want to work on it. *And* I do actually want to bring Angella back, if we can. Micah has some sort of a plan."

Adora stares at her for a moment, gaze contemplative. "Okay. I'm here, however you need."

"And I want to marry you," Catra adds and for a second Adora loses all semblance of composure. Catra almost snickers at her, but refrains. "But can we wait a bit before we actually, you know - have a whole ceremony and all that?"

Adora scrambles for a shred of poise, "Yes! I mean, of course - I kind of thought we'd have a long engagement anyway. And I want us to both be in a good place where we feel ready for it. Together."

"Hmm," Catra hums thoughtfully, "That sounds like a good plan to me. So - where's the badge?"

"Oh no," Adora shakes her head, " *Nope.* I want a do-over."

"What?" Catra asks, voice thin. "A do-over? I already said yes!"

"Technically you still didn't 'say yes'," Adora points out just to be *cocky*. "And yeah-yup. We're having a redo. I want it to be a happy memory."

Fair. But now that Catra's thinking about it, she's sort of excited and *impatient*.

"Okay, but when are you doing to redo it?" She asks, "And *how* ?"

“Not saying,” Adora smiles at her, miming the action of zipping her lips, “But it’s going to be even *better* the second time around. First one was just a test-run.”

“I - you can’t keep a secret,” Catra is *flustered*. She’s touched, actually. Glad that they get a second chance at this, and the memory won’t be sullied by the feelings of panic and self-hatred.

“Guess I’m just going to have to learn,” Adora says, still smiling brightly at her.

Catra can’t handle the arrogant, *so-confident-it’s-smug* look on her face for another second. She loves it, loves seeing Adora happy and *feeling* like they’re on the same page again, but she’s got a better idea in mind. She pulls Adora in for a deep, unhurried kiss. Adora makes a slight noise of surprise before she’s kissing Catra back, slowly and with purpose.

Catra pulls away after a moment or two, leaving Adora a bit flushed when she looks down at her. “Not if I beat you to it.”

Now it’s Adora’s turn to gape, “I-what?”

“Yeah, that’s right. Two can play at this game,” Catra smirks. “I’m so going to out-propose you.”

“That’s-not fair!” Adora protests despite the way she is blushing at the idea, “I already told you I’m going to propose again.”

“And I’m proposing too. Just decided,” Catra says confidently, “Prepare to be *romanced*.”

“Psh - *you* prepare to be romanced,” Adora is competitive, but amused. Happiness is dancing across her features and she laughs a bit when she promises, “I’m romancing you first -”

“We’ll just have to see about that,” Catra rolls her eyes, good naturedly. Adora pulls her in for another kiss and Catra’s mind spins with about a *million* different ideas.

She loves Adora. And Adora loves her. Really, truly.

Catra smiles when they break away again, already imagining a future where, one day - she loves herself, too.

Chapter End Notes

& that's a wrap! thanks for being patient <3

End Notes

this will def be shorter than exile/hoax with less found family and more of a catra-character study BUT I couldn't just leave micah out of this entirely, sorry

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